

**A STUDY ON THE PERCEPTION OF WOMEN EMPLOYEES TOWARDS
LEADERSHIP ROLES WITHIN THE ORGANISATIONAL HIERARCHY**

PROJECT REPORT

Submitted by

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Under the guidance of



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BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the project titled “**A STUDY ON THE PERCEPTION OF WOMEN EMPLOYEES TOWARDS LEADERSHIP ROLES WITHIN THE ORGANISATIONAL HIERARCHY**” is a bonafide project work done by **Ms. Palak Pandey** (Reg No: 2315782022013), a second year student of M.A. HRM, Madras School of Social Work (Autonomous), Egmore, Chennai in partial fulfillment of the requirement for the Award of the Degree of Master of Arts in Human Resource Management and that the project has not been used previously for the award of any Degree, Diploma, Scholarship, Fellowship or any other project title.

Signature of the Guide

Signature of the HOD

DECLARATION

I, **Palak Pandey**, a final year student of **M.A. HRM** hereby declare that the thesis entitled “**A STUDY ON THE PERCEPTION OF WOMEN EMPLOYEES TOWARDS LEADERSHIP ROLES WITHIN THE ORGANISATIONAL HIERARCHY**” is the original work done by me under the guidance and supervision of **Dr. P. Mohana**, in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of the degree of Master of Arts in Human resource Management, Madras School of Social work. I further declare that the research work has not been submitted at any other University or Institution, for the award of any degree or diploma or fellowship.

Signature of the Guide

Signature of the Student

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CHAPTER – 1

INTRODUCTION

The evolving dynamics of the modern workplace have increasingly highlighted the importance of gender diversity and inclusion within organisational hierarchies. Employees often seek representation similar to their identities, particularly women, as it enables them to participate more confidently and build their future within the company. It is human nature to look for opportunities for growth, and in an organization, women in leadership positions positively reinforce the idea that their dedication towards the company's benefits will lead them to a path of growth and opportunities.

In his definition of leadership, the Father of Management, Peter Drucker, stated,

"Leadership is the lifting of a man's vision to higher sights, the raising of a man's performance to a higher standard, the building of a man's personality beyond its normal limitations."

This definition encapsulates his idea of leadership in a precise way but also highlights the fact that traits like leadership are often assumed to be innate to men. Consequently, many such definitions are similarly addressed to them.

In this 21st century, we still face the problem of having significantly few women as board members or in the C-suite, whether in well-established or growing companies. Only five percent of India's 500 listed companies have a woman as a Chief Executive Officer or Managing Director. Among these 500 companies, 319 do not have women as Key Managerial Personnel. Based on market capitalisation, only 27 of the top 500 NSE-listed companies are led by a woman. Women are more likely to lead a company if their family founded it, rather than having the opportunity to become CEO or MD of a company where they have worked alongside their male counterparts. (Businessline, The Hindu).

This research aims to provide a comprehensive analysis of the perception of women leadership within the organizational hierarchy.

1.1 Background and Context:

The underrepresentation of women in leadership positions has long been a subject of global discourse, and while progress has been made, the pace of change remains slow. The historical context of gender inequality in leadership is rooted in societal norms that have traditionally associated leadership with masculine traits such as assertiveness, dominance, and decisiveness. Over time, these associations have become entrenched in organizational structures, often leading to unconscious biases that hinder women's rise to leadership roles.

While some industries, such as healthcare and education, have seen more equitable gender representation in leadership, many sectors—especially heavy engineering, technology, and finance—remain male-dominated. A 2024 report by McKinsey highlighted that even though women now represent 47% of the workforce in many developed countries, their presence in senior leadership positions drops dramatically, often falling below 20%. The organizational structure, cultural norms, and leadership development pathways within these industries can sometimes serve as barriers to the advancement of women.

This study is set against the backdrop of these structural inequalities, focusing on women's perceptions of leadership roles in corporate environments. The aim is to understand the specific challenges they face, the organizational support systems in place, and how their aspirations align with the leadership opportunities available to them. Gendered expectations, organizational culture, and personal motivations all play a role in shaping how women navigate their careers and perceive their prospects for leadership advancement.

1.2. Key Concepts and Definitions:

To fully understand the complexities surrounding women's leadership in organizations, it's essential to clarify the key concepts that frame this study.

Leadership:

Leadership has traditionally been viewed as the ability to direct and guide individuals or groups toward a common goal. McKinsey (2024) defines leadership as an activity focused on enabling others to achieve something they couldn't on their own. This definition moves away from the notion that leadership is tied to authority or position. Instead, leadership is seen as an influence, often derived from behavior and the ability to foster trust and commitment within teams.

Modern leadership theories emphasize that effective leaders exhibit behaviors such as empathy, inclusivity, and the ability to solve complex problems. Leadership styles can vary widely—from transformational, which focuses on inspiring and motivating teams, to transactional, which is based on clear structures and reward systems. Each style comes with its advantages and disadvantages, and the effectiveness of any style may depend on the organization's context.

Gender Diversity:

Gender diversity refers to the equitable representation of different genders within all levels of an organization. Gender diversity goes beyond equal numbers; it implies creating an inclusive environment where both men and women have equal opportunities for professional growth, leadership roles, and decision-making power. The inclusion of women in leadership not only brings diversity of thought but also has been shown to improve organizational performance. However, many organizations still grapple with achieving true gender diversity, especially at senior levels.

Glass Ceiling:

The "glass ceiling" metaphor describes the invisible yet powerful barriers that prevent women from ascending to top leadership positions, regardless of their qualifications or achievements. These barriers are often the result of implicit biases, organizational cultures that favor men, and structural obstacles such as lack of mentorship or networking opportunities. While significant progress has been made to break the glass ceiling, many women still experience challenges in reaching the highest levels of organizational hierarchies.

1.3. Statement of Research Problem:

The core issue that this research aims to address is the disparity between the growing number of women entering the workforce and the relatively low number who attain leadership positions. Despite the implementation of various gender diversity and inclusion initiatives, many organizations continue to exhibit significant gender imbalances in leadership roles.

This disparity raises several questions that this research will seek to answer:

Perception of Leadership Opportunities: How do women in corporate environments perceive the availability and accessibility of leadership opportunities? Do they believe they have equal chances compared to their male counterparts?

Barriers to Leadership: What are the key barriers, both organizational and societal, that women face in ascending to leadership roles? Are these barriers more pronounced in specific industries or organizational structures?

Impact of Organizational Culture: How does the culture within an organization—its policies, leadership development programs, and attitude towards gender diversity—impact women's perceptions of their leadership potential?

Women's Aspirations and Leadership: To what extent do women aspire to leadership positions, and how do their aspirations align with the opportunities available within their organizations?

1.4. Need, Scope, and Significance of the Study:

Gender diversity in leadership brings a wide range of perspectives, fosters creativity, and can lead to better decision-making. Studies, including those from McKinsey (2024), have shown that companies with higher levels of gender diversity, particularly in leadership roles, perform better financially. Therefore, understanding women's perceptions of leadership roles is crucial for organizations aiming to foster inclusive environments and improve their overall performance.

Need for the Study:

Despite the implementation of policies aimed at promoting gender diversity, the number of women in leadership roles remains disproportionately low. Understanding the perception of women employees is critical to identifying the gaps between policy and practice. This study is needed to shed light on:

- The effectiveness of current diversity and inclusion initiatives.
- The challenges women perceive as hindrances to their leadership ambitions.
- The impact of these perceptions on organizational performance and employee satisfaction.

Scope of the Study:

The study will focus on corporate organizations across various sectors in Chennai, with particular emphasis on industries where women are significantly underrepresented in leadership roles e.g. manufacturing, construction, finance. The primary participants of the study will be men and women in middle-management and entry-level roles, providing a perspective on their career aspirations, challenges, and perceptions of leadership opportunities.

Significance of the Study:

The findings of this research will be significant for several reasons:

- **For Organisations:** Insights from this study can help organizations refine their gender diversity strategies and implement more effective women leadership development programs.
- **For Policy Makers:** The study will provide data that can inform policies aimed at bridging the gender gap in leadership roles.
- **For Women Employees:** Understanding the challenges and opportunities in leadership can help women navigate their career paths more strategically.

1.5. Industry Profile:

While the study does not focus on a specific company, it is essential to understand the general industry dynamics affecting women in leadership roles. Various industries have different gender representation levels, with sectors like finance, technology, and heavy engineering often showing a significant gender gap in leadership.

Industry Trends in Gender Diversity:

Recent data indicate that industries such as healthcare and education have made significant strides in gender diversity, with women holding a considerable number of leadership positions. In contrast, industries such as heavy engineering, construction, and technology remain largely male-dominated at the executive level. These industries often cite challenges such as long-standing gender biases, lack of female role models, and inadequate mentorship programs as reasons for the low representation of women in leadership.

Organisational Culture and Its Impact on Leadership:

Organizational culture plays a critical role in shaping women's perceptions of leadership opportunities. Companies with a more inclusive culture tend to provide better support systems, such as mentorship programs, leadership training, and flexible work arrangements, all of which are crucial for women aspiring to leadership roles. Conversely, companies with rigid, hierarchical structures often create environments that are less conducive to women's leadership development.

1.6. Limitations of the Study:

No research is without its limitations, and this study acknowledges several constraints that may impact the findings:

- **Geographical Limitation:** The study is geographically confined to corporate organizations in India. Cultural factors that influence gender dynamics in leadership may differ significantly from those in other countries, potentially limiting the generalizability of the findings to a global context.
- **Sample Size and Diversity:** While the study aims to gather data from a diverse range of industries, the number of participants may limit the extent to which the findings can be generalized across all sectors.
- **Subjectivity of Perceptions:** The study focuses on women's perceptions, which are inherently subjective. While this provides valuable insights, it may not fully capture the structural factors influencing leadership dynamics.
- **Lack of Longitudinal Data:** The study is cross-sectional, meaning it captures perceptions at a single point in time. A longitudinal approach would offer a more comprehensive understanding of how women's perceptions of leadership evolve over time.

1.7. Chapterisation:

The structure of the study will follow a logical progression, from the introduction of the research problem to the discussion of findings and recommendations for future action:

Chapter 1: Introduction

This chapter sets the stage for the research by providing the background, defining key concepts, and explaining the research problem and its significance.

Chapter 2: Review of Literature

This chapter will provide an overview of the existing body of research on women's leadership, gender diversity, and organizational dynamics. It will highlight key theories and empirical studies that have shaped our understanding of these issues.

Chapter 3: Research Methodology

This chapter will outline the research design, data collection methods (e.g., surveys and interviews), and analysis techniques used to gather and interpret the data.

Chapter 4: Data Analysis and Interpretation

The core of the research, this chapter will present the findings from the data collected and provide insights into women's perceptions of leadership within their organisations.

Chapter 5: Findings and Conclusions

This chapter will discuss the findings in relation to the research problem and the existing literature. It will also address any unexpected results or anomalies. In addition to that it will conclude the research and provide suggestions to effectively implement the findings.

CHAPTER - 2

REVIEW OF

LITERATURE

2.1. Theoretical Framework

2.1.1. Perception of Women Towards Leadership Roles

Women's perceptions of leadership roles play a significant role in shaping their career aspirations, ambitions, and confidence in pursuing leadership positions. Several studies suggest that while women often express interest in leadership, many are hesitant to pursue these roles due to perceived or real challenges associated with them. These perceptions are frequently influenced by societal norms, organizational culture, and personal experiences within their careers.

Theoretical frameworks like Social Role Theory and Role Congruity Theory have been used to explain how gendered expectations shape women's perceptions of leadership. For example, leadership traits such as assertiveness, decisiveness, and authority have traditionally been associated with men, leading women to sometimes perceive a disconnect between their personal traits and what is expected in leadership roles.

Numerous international bodies, scholars, and organizations have emphasized the need for equal opportunities for men and women in professional spheres, particularly within leadership positions. Despite these efforts, women continue to be underrepresented in leadership roles, especially at the highest levels of organizational hierarchies. The slow progress towards gender parity in leadership raises important questions about the systemic barriers women face and how they perceive their potential for leadership.

This literature review aims to delve into the existing body of research related to women's representation in leadership positions, focusing on several key dimensions: the perceptions of women employees regarding leadership roles, the barriers that hinder their ascent to leadership, and case studies from diverse industries that showcase both successes and ongoing challenges. By examining theoretical frameworks and empirical studies, this review will provide a comprehensive understanding of the issues surrounding women's underrepresentation in leadership, while also identifying gaps in the literature that may require further exploration.

2.1.2. Leadership Definitions

Burns (1978): Leadership is the reciprocal process of mobilizing, by persons with certain motives and values, various economic, political, and other resources, in a context of competition and conflict, in order to realize goals independently or mutually held by both leaders and followers.

Yukl (2013): Leadership is the process of influencing others to understand and agree about what needs to be done and how to do it, and the process of facilitating individual and collective efforts to accomplish shared objectives.

Uhl-Bien and Arena (2018): Leadership is an enabling process that enhances adaptive capacity in complex environments by fostering collaboration, encouraging innovation, and enabling organizations to meet changing demands.

2.1.3 Hierarchy and Organizational Hierarchy Definitions:

Mintzberg (1983): Organizational hierarchy is the arrangement of authority and responsibility in which the levels of the hierarchy correspond to the decision-making rights and information flow within the organization.

Kendall et al. (2019): Hierarchy is a formal system of ranking individuals or groups based on their level of authority and control within an organization, often used to distribute responsibilities and decision-making power.

2.1.4. Perception Definitions

Frith and Friston (2018): Perception is a predictive process where the brain constructs a model of the world based on sensory data and predictions derived from prior experiences, enabling individuals to make sense of their surroundings.

Goldstein and Brockmole (2021): Perception is the process of recognizing, organizing, and interpreting sensory information, primarily through visual, auditory, and tactile cues, to understand one's environment and make appropriate responses.

2.1.5. Work-Life Balance Definitions

Kossek et al. (2021): Work-life balance is the harmonious arrangement of work and non-work activities that promotes wellbeing and minimizes conflict, enabling individuals to engage effectively in both domains.

Greenhaus and Powell (2019): Work-life balance is the degree to which an individual is equally engaged and satisfied with work and family roles, without experiencing significant conflict between the two.

2.1.6. Other Definitions

Gender Equality

Gender equality refers to the equal rights, responsibilities, and opportunities for individuals of all genders. It is a principle that emphasizes fairness and justice in the treatment of women and men, aiming to eliminate discrimination and barriers based on gender. According to the United Nations (UN), gender equality is not just a fundamental human right but a necessary foundation for a peaceful, prosperous, and sustainable world (UN Women, 2021).

Transformational Leadership

Transformational leadership is a leadership style that emphasizes vision, inspiration, and the ability to bring about change through motivation and support. According to Bass (1985), transformational leaders inspire followers to transcend their self-interests for the good of the organization and foster an environment of creativity and innovation. Women are often seen as more likely to adopt transformational leadership styles.

Intersectionality

Intersectionality is a concept that highlights how different social identities—such as gender, race, class, and sexual orientation—intersect to shape individuals' experiences of privilege and oppression. Crenshaw (1989) introduced the term to describe how black women face unique challenges that cannot be understood solely by looking at gender or race in isolation.

Implicit Bias

Implicit bias refers to the unconscious attitudes or stereotypes that affect our understanding, actions, and decisions in an unconscious manner. Banaji and Greenwald (2013) define implicit bias as “the relatively unconscious and relatively automatic features of prejudiced judgment and social behavior.”

2.1.7. Feminist Leadership Theories:

Feminist leadership theories focus on the way societal expectations and power dynamics influence leadership opportunities for women. These theories argue that leadership is often conceptualized in a way that privileges masculine qualities such as assertiveness, decisiveness, and competitiveness, while undervaluing traits traditionally associated with women, such as empathy, collaboration, and nurturing. Feminist leadership theories critique these traditional models of leadership and propose alternative approaches that embrace gender diversity and promote egalitarian leadership styles.

Central to feminist leadership theory is the concept of “transformational leadership,” which emphasizes inclusive, participatory, and empowering leadership practices. Scholars such as Jean Lipman-Blumen and Carol Gilligan argue that women are more likely to engage in transformational leadership styles that foster collaboration and mentorship, as opposed to transactional leadership styles, which focus on hierarchy and control. According to these theories, the underrepresentation of women in leadership stems from the fact that organizational cultures often reward transactional leadership, which is more commonly associated with male leaders, while undervaluing transformational approaches.

i. Glass Ceiling Theory:

The Glass Ceiling Theory refers to the invisible but formidable barriers that prevent women from advancing to senior leadership positions, despite their qualifications and abilities. This metaphor captures the idea that while women can rise through the ranks to middle management, they often encounter a “ceiling” that blocks their further advancement to top-tier leadership roles, such as C-suite positions or board memberships. The glass ceiling is composed of a variety of factors, including entrenched biases, institutional structures, and discriminatory practices that disproportionately affect women.

Research on the glass ceiling suggests that the phenomenon is not just a product of individual discrimination but is embedded within organizational practices and societal norms.

These cultural norms create an environment in which women are systematically overlooked for promotions to leadership roles, even when they have demonstrated equal or superior competence.

ii. Role Congruity Theory:

Role Congruity Theory, introduced by Alice Eagly and Steven Karau, explains the prejudice that women leaders face as a result of the perceived mismatch between gender roles and leadership roles. According to this theory, societal expectations about gender create distinct norms for men and women. This perceived incongruity leads to two forms of prejudice. First, women may be viewed as less suitable for leadership roles because their expected communal traits are seen as inconsistent with the agentic traits typically associated with leadership. Second, women who do adopt more agentic, leadership-oriented behaviors may be viewed unfavorably because they are perceived as violating traditional gender norms. This creates a “double bind” for women leaders: they are criticized both for being too feminine to lead and for being too masculine when they do lead assertively.

Role Congruity Theory has been widely supported by empirical research, which demonstrates that women leaders often face harsher evaluations and more skepticism than their male counterparts, even when performing at the same level. This bias not only affects women’s chances of being promoted to leadership positions but also influences their experiences once they are in leadership roles, as they may face greater scrutiny and less support.

iii. Queen Bee Syndrome:

The Queen Bee Syndrome refers to a phenomenon where women in leadership positions distance themselves from other women in order to maintain their status within male-dominated environments. According to this theory, women leaders may adopt more masculine behaviors and attitudes to fit into organizational cultures that value traditionally male leadership traits. In doing so, they may become unsupportive or even critical of other women seeking leadership roles, viewing them as competitors rather than allies.

Empirical studies have shown that women in leadership positions are sometimes reluctant to mentor or promote other women, often out of fear that doing so will undermine their own standing within the organization.

iv. **Tokenism Theory:**

Tokenism Theory, proposed by Rosabeth Moss Kanter, explains the dynamics that occur when women (or other underrepresented groups) are present in very small numbers within an organization or leadership team. In such situations, women may be viewed as “tokens” — individuals who are seen as representing their entire gender, rather than as individuals with unique talents and qualifications. This token status places additional pressures on women leaders, who may feel the need to outperform their male counterparts in order to prove their worth.

Kanter’s research found that tokens often face heightened visibility, which can lead to increased scrutiny and pressure to conform to organizational norms. At the same time, tokens may be socially isolated from their colleagues and excluded from informal networks that are critical to career advancement. These dynamics make it more difficult for women to succeed in leadership roles and can perpetuate the underrepresentation of women in these positions. Tokenism also exacerbates the challenges of stereotyping and bias, as women in leadership may be seen as exceptions to the norm rather than as part of a broader trend towards gender equality. This can reinforce the idea that women are less suited for leadership roles and make it harder for other women to follow in their footsteps.

v. **Stereotype Threat Theory:**

Stereotype Threat Theory, developed by Claude Steele and Joshua Aronson, describes the psychological experience of individuals who belong to a group that is negatively stereotyped in a particular domain. In the context of leadership, women may experience stereotype threat when they are aware of societal stereotypes that suggest they are less capable leaders than men. This awareness can create anxiety and self-doubt, which in turn can undermine their performance and confidence in leadership roles.

Research on stereotype threat has shown that it can have a significant impact on women’s aspirations to leadership positions. Women who are reminded of gender stereotypes about leadership may be less likely to pursue leadership roles or may perform worse in leadership tasks due to the added pressure of disproving the stereotype. Stereotype threat can also contribute to a lack of self-efficacy, as women may internalize societal messages that they are not suited for leadership.

vi. **Social Role Theory:**

Social Role Theory, developed by Alice Eagly, posits that gender differences in behavior are largely a result of the societal roles that men and women are expected to fulfill. In most societies, men are expected to take on agentic roles that emphasize independence, ambition, and leadership, while women are expected to take on communal roles that emphasize caregiving, cooperation, and support. These gender roles shape individuals' behaviors, career choices, and leadership aspirations.

According to Social Role Theory, the underrepresentation of women in leadership is a reflection of the way gender roles are structured within society. Women are often socialized to prioritize family responsibilities and communal tasks, which can limit their opportunities for leadership development. Moreover, organizational cultures may reinforce these gender roles by promoting men to leadership positions more readily than women, even when women demonstrate the necessary leadership qualities.

2.2. Empirical Research

- From **"Role of Female Leadership in Corporate Innovation" (Khushk et al., 2022)**, Khushk et al. conducted a comprehensive review of 35 empirical studies to explore the impact of female leadership on corporate innovation. Their findings indicate a strong correlation between the presence of female CEOs and an organization's propensity for innovative practices. The authors argue that female leaders tend to foster environments that encourage creativity and collaboration, ultimately driving organizational growth and adaptability.

Despite these promising insights, the research also points out the significant barriers that female leaders continue to face, particularly in terms of bias and discrimination. The study calls for a reevaluation of leadership criteria and suggests that organizations need to recognize and mitigate these biases to fully leverage the benefits of female leadership in driving innovation.

- **"The Status of Women in Leadership" (Alqahtani, 2020)**, Alqahtani's literature review critically examines the enduring issue of gender segregation in leadership roles, despite an increase in female labor force participation. The review reveals that while women are entering the workforce in greater numbers, their representation in top management positions remains disproportionately low. The study highlights how male-normed corporate structures continue to obstruct women's advancement, creating significant gaps in leadership representation. This persistent disparity reflects not only societal norms but also institutional barriers that perpetuate gender inequality within organizations.

The review suggests that addressing these systemic issues is crucial for closing the gender gap in leadership and enhancing organizational effectiveness. Ultimately, Alqahtani's work calls for a collective effort to transform organizational frameworks and cultures to better support and promote female leadership.

- Wolfram et al. explore the intersection of gender self-perceptions and workplace leadership in **"Gender, Gender Self-Perceptions, and Workplace Leadership"** (Wolfram et al., 2020) through the lens of role congruity theory. Their study identifies a significant disconnect between societal expectations of traditional female roles and the expectations associated with leadership positions. This incongruence often leads to negative evaluations of women leaders, who may be perceived as less competent or authoritative. The findings underscore how deeply rooted gender stereotypes can create formidable barriers for women in leadership, contributing to their underrepresentation in top positions.

Additionally, the research highlights the importance of addressing these stereotypes to improve women's leadership outcomes. By promoting female leaders and showcasing their successes, organizations can work toward dismantling stereotypes and fostering a more inclusive leadership landscape.

- **"Female Leadership: A Qualitative Study"** (Taveira & Silva, 2019)

In their qualitative study, Taveira and Silva investigate the myriad challenges faced by women leaders, utilizing semi-structured interviews to gather rich insights. The study reveals that gender bias and family responsibilities are prominent obstacles that women encounter in leadership roles. Many participants reported feelings of isolation and the pressure to conform to traditional gender roles, which can hinder their professional growth and leadership aspirations. This qualitative approach allows for a deeper understanding of the personal and organizational factors that shape women's experiences in leadership.

Despite these challenges, Taveira and Silva also uncover opportunities for growth through mentorship and supportive networks. The study suggests that organizations should actively cultivate mentoring programs and support systems that empower women leaders. By fostering an environment where women can share experiences and learn from one another, organizations can help mitigate the challenges they face and promote greater gender equity in leadership.

- In **"Women Leaders and Organizational Diversity" (Gupta, 2019)**, Gupta's analysis examines the relationship between female leadership and organizational diversity, highlighting the positive impact that women have on fostering inclusive environments. The study indicates that women leaders are more likely to prioritize diversity initiatives, resulting in organizations that not only value but actively promote inclusivity. This focus on diversity not only enhances team dynamics but also drives better decision-making processes, as varied perspectives lead to more comprehensive solutions. Gupta's findings underscore the critical role that women leaders play in shaping organizational culture toward inclusivity.

Gupta advocates for the need to dismantle these biases and to implement policies that actively support women's advancement in leadership. By recognizing the economic and social benefits of gender diversity, organizations can create strategies that not only elevate women but also enhance overall organizational performance.
- Seo and Huang's research **"Social Perceptions, Gender Roles, and Female Leadership" (Seo & Huang, 2017)** addresses the barriers women face in advancing to leadership roles, particularly focusing on the concept of the "glass ceiling."

Their study underscores how organizational structures and prevailing social perceptions contribute to this phenomenon, which consistently undervalues women's leadership potential. The authors argue that despite women often exhibiting effective leadership qualities, societal expectations and biases limit their opportunities for advancement. This systematic undervaluation creates a challenging landscape for aspiring female leaders.

The study also emphasizes the need for organizations to confront these biases actively. Seo and Huang call for initiatives that educate employees about gender biases and promote equitable practices within the workplace. They argue that such efforts are essential for dismantling barriers and creating pathways for women to ascend to leadership positions, thereby enriching organizational dynamics with diverse leadership perspectives.

- **"Perceptions of Leadership: Impact of Leadership Style and Gender on Employee Motivation" (Walker, 2015)**, reveals that while gender did not significantly affect overall motivation levels, the type of leadership style employed had a substantial impact. Specifically, laissez-faire leadership was found to yield higher employee motivation compared to transformational or transactional styles. These findings challenge conventional leadership theories that often emphasize transformational leadership as the most effective approach, suggesting that different styles may resonate differently with diverse employee groups. By understanding the specific contexts in which different styles may be more effective, leaders can tailor their approaches to maximize motivation and productivity.

The research underscores the importance of recognizing individual and situational factors that influence leadership effectiveness, advocating for a more nuanced understanding of how gender and leadership styles interact in the workplace.

- **"Professionals' Perception of Male and Female Leaders" (Seifart et al., 2014)** explore the perceptions surrounding male and female leaders, revealing that women often face hurdles in being promoted to leadership roles due to biases that associate leadership with masculine traits. Despite this challenge, the study finds that women are perceived as more transformational leaders, which can foster trust and collaboration among employees. This duality reflects the complexities of gender dynamics within leadership, as women navigate both the benefits and barriers presented by their gender. The study also emphasizes the importance of organizational practices in shaping perceptions of female leaders. By actively promoting diverse leadership representations and challenging traditional notions of competence, organizations can work to create more equitable environments. Seifart et al. advocate for training programs aimed at bias awareness and leadership development, which can help in reshaping perceptions and facilitating a more inclusive approach to leadership selection and promotion.

- **"An Examination of Gender Impact on Leadership Style and Job Satisfaction"** (Jackson et al., 2014) delves into the relationship between gender and leadership preferences, highlighting a shift in modern workplaces toward valuing leadership traits traditionally associated with women, such as empathy and collaboration. The study reveals that these qualities are increasingly recognized as vital for effective leadership, suggesting a transformation in how leadership is perceived. This shift reflects broader societal changes regarding gender roles and leadership expectations, indicating a potential pathway for enhancing women's representation in leadership positions.
- **"South African Female Leaders' Perceptions of Gender and Leadership Roles"** (Ramaite, 2013), Ramaite's study provides insight into the perceptions of South African female leaders regarding gender and leadership roles. The research reveals that women in leadership positions face significant socio-cultural and organizational barriers, including challenges related to work-life balance and gender bias. Many participants expressed the need for supportive structures that can help them navigate these challenges, emphasizing the role of mentorship and community in fostering their leadership development. This qualitative exploration highlights the unique struggles faced by women in different cultural contexts, underscoring the necessity of tailored support systems.
- Chin's work explores the complexities of how women's leadership styles are perceived within organizations, **"Women and Leadership: Transforming Visions"** (Chin, 2011) often being categorized as either too soft or too domineering. The study examines the tension between societal expectations of femininity and the assertiveness typically associated with effective leadership. This duality poses significant challenges for women, who must navigate these stereotypes to establish their credibility as leaders. Chin emphasizes that these perceptions can hinder women's leadership advancement and calls for a reevaluation of what constitutes effective leadership in contemporary organizations.

- **"Women's Perceptions of Organizational Culture and Role-Modeling" (Jandeska & Kraimer, 2005)**, investigates the critical role of role modeling and mentorship in shaping women's perceptions of organizational culture. Their study highlights that women who engage in mentorship experiences often report higher career satisfaction and progression, indicating that positive role models can significantly influence women's leadership trajectories. The research underscores the need for organizations to foster a culture of mentorship that actively supports the development of female leaders, facilitating their advancement within corporate structures.

Additionally, the study emphasizes the importance of creating an organizational culture that values diversity and inclusivity. By promoting environments where women can see themselves represented in leadership roles, organizations can help mitigate feelings of isolation and reinforce the belief in their own leadership potential. Janeska and Kraimer argue that organizations should actively cultivate such cultures to enhance women's engagement and commitment, ultimately leading to improved organizational outcomes and greater gender equity in leadership.

- **"Women Executives and Corporate Growth" (Carter & Wagener, 2004)** explores the relationship between female representation at senior management levels and corporate growth. Their findings indicate that organizations with higher female representation in leadership roles experience significant improvements in capital return, suggesting that gender diversity is not just a matter of equity but also a strategic advantage. This study highlights the economic value of promoting women into leadership positions, demonstrating that diversity in leadership can lead to better decision-making and enhanced organizational performance.

The research also calls attention to the need for organizations to actively pursue gender diversity at the leadership level. By implementing policies that support the recruitment and retention of female leaders, companies can tap into the diverse perspectives and experiences that women bring to the table.

Carter and Wagener advocate for the development of strategic initiatives aimed at elevating women within corporate structures, emphasizing that doing so can yield substantial benefits for both the organization and its stakeholders.

- Davidson and Burke's research "**Breaking Through the Glass Ceiling: Leadership Challenges for Women**" (Davidson & Burke, 2002) documents the ongoing challenges that women face in advancing to top management roles, particularly the metaphorical "glass ceiling." The study identifies various barriers, including gender bias and organizational structures that favor male leadership styles. Despite these obstacles, the authors note the emergence of women's leadership development programs as a key strategy for mitigating these challenges. These programs can provide women with the skills, confidence, and networks necessary to navigate the complexities of leadership within male-dominated environments.
- "**Leadership Stereotypes: Women in Male-Dominated Fields**" (Eagly & Karau, 1995), Eagly and Karau's study utilizes role congruity theory to explain the barriers women encounter in male-dominated industries. The research highlights that women are often perceived as less competent leaders due to prevailing stereotypes that associate leadership with masculine traits. This perception creates significant challenges for women seeking leadership roles in these fields, as they may be unfairly judged against standards that do not align with their leadership styles. The study underscores the importance of addressing these stereotypes to promote more equitable perceptions of women's leadership potential.
- "**Gender and Leadership Effectiveness**" (Eagly et al., 1990) Eagly et al. conducted a meta-analysis comparing the leadership styles and effectiveness of men and women. Their findings reveal that women are often perceived as more transformational leaders, excelling in interpersonal relationships and team dynamics. This effectiveness, however, is tempered by negative biases, particularly in male-dominated environments where traditional notions of leadership persist. The study highlights the complexities of gender dynamics in leadership, illustrating that while women may possess valuable leadership qualities, they still face significant hurdles in being recognized and promoted.
The authors further emphasize the need for organizations to reassess their leadership evaluation criteria and to recognize the contributions of women leaders. Eagly et al. advocate for initiatives that support women's leadership development landscape.

- Schein's foundational research identifies gender-role stereotyping as a significant factor contributing to the underrepresentation of women in leadership roles "**The Role of Gender in Leadership Stereotyping**" (Schein, 1989). The study concludes that male leaders are often perceived as more competent by default, creating a substantial bias against women in leadership assessments. This phenomenon reinforces the notion that leadership is inherently masculine, which can deter organizations from recognizing the capabilities of female leaders. Schein's work sheds light on the systemic nature of gender bias in leadership, highlighting the urgent need for cultural change within organizations.

Furthermore, Schein emphasizes the importance of addressing these stereotypes through targeted organizational initiatives. By promoting gender awareness and creating equitable leadership opportunities, organizations can work to dismantle these entrenched biases. The study serves as a call for organizations to critically examine their leadership paradigms and actively foster an environment that values diversity and inclusivity. This foundational research continues to resonate, informing ongoing discussions about gender and leadership in contemporary contexts.

- "**Organizational Commitment and Leadership Role Perceptions**" (Kanter, 1977), Kanter's seminal work on organizational commitment explores the impact of gender biases on leadership role perceptions. The research highlights how prevailing stereotypes shape perceptions of leadership effectiveness, often limiting women's advancement opportunities within organizations. Kanter's findings indicate that women are frequently seen as less committed to leadership roles due to societal expectations regarding gender roles, creating significant barriers to their professional growth. This work underscores the critical intersection of gender and organizational dynamics in shaping leadership pathways.

Additionally, Kanter advocates for organizational reforms that actively challenge these biases and promote gender equity in leadership. By fostering inclusive cultures that value diverse leadership styles, organizations can create more equitable opportunities for women. The study serves as a foundational reference for understanding the complexities of gender and leadership, urging organizations to prioritize commitment to diversity and inclusion in their leadership development strategies.

- **"Gender Differences in Leadership Perception: Transformational vs. Transactional Styles" (Bass & Avolio, 1994)**, Bass and Avolio's study highlights the perception that women excel in transformational leadership roles, which are increasingly valued in modern organizations. Their research reveals that while women often demonstrate effectiveness in these styles, they still encounter biases that impede their advancement to higher leadership positions. This study illustrates the dichotomy between women's leadership capabilities and the barriers they face in achieving recognition and promotion. It calls attention to reevaluate their leadership criteria to fully embrace and leverage the strengths of female leaders.

Moreover, the authors emphasize the importance of creating supportive environments that enable women to thrive in leadership roles. By recognizing and valuing transformational leadership traits, organizations can foster greater gender equity in leadership. Bass and Avolio's findings encourage a reevaluation of traditional leadership frameworks, advocating for inclusive practices that empower women to reach their full potential in leadership positions.
- **In Gender and Organizational Culture: Perceptions of Leadership Style and Effectiveness, 2022**, Vecchio's study delves into the evolving perceptions of leadership styles attributed to gender, highlighting that women executives are increasingly recognized as more transformational compared to their male counterparts. This shift suggests a positive organizational culture that embraces diversity and inclusivity can facilitate this shift, promoting female leaders as effective change agents.

The study emphasizes the critical role organizational culture plays in either amplifying or mitigating deeply entrenched gender biases which often cloud perceptions, leading to slower rates of change in organizational structures.

2.3. Gap in Research

1. Impact of Organizational Culture on Women's Leadership Progression:

Although the previous researches touch upon the influence of organizational culture, the literature review lacks specific insights into which elements of culture (e.g., organizational support, work-life balance etc.) most significantly impact women's advancement. Investigating specific organizational changes that would positively influence women's leadership progression could bridge this gap.

2. Quantification of the Impact of Women Leaders on Organizational Outcomes:

This study can fill the gap by providing quantitative data on how women leaders impact specific organizational outcomes, such as influence team performance, morale, conflict resolution, and creativity, making a stronger case for promoting women to leadership roles.

3. Work-Life Balance and Leadership Aspirations:

While the literature points out the impact of work-life balance issues on leadership progression, more nuanced research is needed to understand how work-life balance policies influence leadership aspirations specifically for women. This study can fill this gap by examining whether organizations with better work-life balance see a higher aspiration among women employees to pursue leadership roles.

4. Organizational Support for Women in Leadership:

While some data points to a lack of support from supervisors, there is little depth in understanding the types of support (e.g., leadership training, mentorship) that women find most valuable. Your research could further explore the nature of support systems that women believe would most effectively help them ascend to leadership positions.

Conclusion:

Theories such as feminist leadership theories, Glass Ceiling Theory, Role Congruity Theory, Queen Bee Syndrome, Tokenism, Stereotype Threat, and Social Role Theory provide valuable insights into the persistent underrepresentation of women in leadership positions. Each theory highlights different aspects of the barriers that women face, from societal norms and organizational structures to psychological challenges and interpersonal dynamics. Together, these theories underscore the complexity of the gender leadership gap and the need for multifaceted approaches to promoting gender equality in leadership. As organizations continue to strive for more diverse and inclusive leadership teams, understanding and addressing these theoretical frameworks will be essential to creating lasting change.

The reviewed empirical studies collectively highlight both the progress and persistent challenges women face in leadership roles across various industries and organizational cultures. Key themes emerge around the effectiveness of female leadership, particularly in transformational styles that emphasize empathy, collaboration, and inclusivity. These leadership qualities are increasingly recognized as essential for innovation and organizational success.

The collective research underscores the importance of both structural reforms and cultural shifts in promoting women's leadership, ultimately benefiting organizations through enhanced decision-making, innovation, and growth.

CHAPTER – 3

RESEARCH

METHODOLOGY

3.1. Objectives of the Study:

Primary Objective:

1. To explore perceptions of both male and female employees towards women in leadership positions.

Secondary Objectives:

2. To identify Barriers and Challenges women face in advancing to leadership positions.
3. To evaluate the Impact of Women Leaders on various aspects of the organisation.
4. To provide Recommendations for Improvement.

3.2. Hypotheses of the Study:

Hypothesis 1 - There is a significant difference in perceptions of women's representation in leadership roles.

Hypothesis 2- Organisational culture significantly impacts women's advancement to leadership positions.

Hypothesis 3 - Work-life balance issues significantly affect women's leadership opportunities.

Hypothesis 4 - There is a significant impact of Women Leaderships on team performance, morale, conflict resolution, and creativity.

3.3. Research Design:

A descriptive research design is employed in this study to provide a comprehensive understanding of the key variables - perception and female leadership.

Descriptive study - Descriptive research is defined as a research method that describes the characteristics of the population or phenomenon studied. This methodology focuses more on the "what" of the research subject than the "why" of the research subject.

3.4. Research Approach:

The research approach used is quantitative.

Quantitative research is the process of collecting and analyzing numerical data. It can be used to find patterns and averages, make predictions, test causal relationships, and generalize results to wider populations. By using the quantitative approach, we can collect reliable data which will provide a wider scope for data analysis and reduce bias.

3.5. Sources of Data:

The source of data used is a sample survey.

A sample survey is a method for collecting data from or about the members of a population so that inferences about the entire population can be obtained from a subset, or sample, of the population members.

3.6. Sampling Plan:

Non-probability convenience sampling is utilized in this investigation because of the research objective's practicality and cost-effectiveness. It entails employees who are conveniently accessible and immediately available. This sample strategy streamlines data collection by enabling for a detailed study.

- (i) Population and sampling unit:** All the elements under consideration collectively form a Universe or Population. In this research, the population consists of individuals from diverse sectors, encompassing various age groups, genders, levels of experience, and job titles across Chennai. Approximately 1,200 employees, made up the population of interest for this study. The target population is working professionals who have access to basic internet facilities, and should be old enough to use technological gadgets (phone, tablet, computer, and laptop).

- (ii) Sample size:** The sample size is 126 respondents with a mix of genders, designations and ages who represent the total population. The sample size decision is influenced by the willingness and availability of respondents, as it directly affects the study's ability to draw generalizable conclusions.

3.7. Methods of Data Collection:

Data constitutes a collection of information crucial for this research to address a given problem. The collected data encompasses various forms, including factual details, descriptive information, both numerical and non-numerical, and quantitative and qualitative insights.

(i) Primary Data:

The data for the research study was collected as primary data representing the information acquired firsthand through a questionnaire. The data used for the study has not been previously published or made available in any form. All the 23 questions were originated from an original research study. The data collected is also organized with the research objectives in mind to serve the purpose of analysis and evaluation.

Mode of Data Collection: The data was collected through a self-constructed questionnaire since it proved to be less expensive when compared to other methods and it could be administered to a large group of respondents in a short period.

(ii) Secondary Data:

This refers to a source of information that has already been published in any form.

Mode of Data Collection: This information has been collected through information about the industry and other general details have been collected from various journals, articles, magazines, and the internet.

3.8. Tools and techniques used for Analysis:

Google, Microsoft Excel, and SPSS will be used to analyze and interpret the data. The methods used in SPSS are:

- a. Descriptive Statistics –Percentage and Frequesncy
- b. Inferential Statistics – Spearman’s Correlation, ANOVA.

3.9. Pilot Study:

A pilot study was conducted with a sample size of 30 participants to inform and refine the methodology for the main study. This small-scale preliminary study aimed to test and validate the research methodology, data collection instruments, and identify potential issues or challenges in the research design. The insights gained will be used to make necessary adjustments and enhancements, ultimately increasing the validity and reliability of the findings in the main study, which will have a larger sample size.

3.10. Reliability Test:

Cronbach's Alpha is a frequently employed metric for assessing the reliability of a set of two or more indicators of constructs. It offers a range of values from 0 to 1.0, with higher values signifying greater reliability among the items. In this research, Cronbach's Alpha is utilized to evaluate the internal consistency of the scale. The overall reliability value for this research is 0.839.

VARIABLES		RELIABILITY STATISTICS
CRONBACH'S ALPHA		NO.OF. ITEMS
OVERALL	0.754	18
Perception of Leadership Roles	0.732	7
Leadership Opportunity	0.699	3
Barriers and Challenges	0.758	5
Work-Life Balance	0.825	3

Table 3.9.1 Reliability Statistics Table

CHAPTER - 4

ANALYSIS

4.1. Percentage Analysis

The primary source of the data was a questionnaire. Each question has been converted into a tabular format. These tables show the categorization of the data as well as the percentages for each category.

Demographic Details:

Table No. 4.1.1 Gender Wise Classification

GENDER	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE (%)
Male	66	52.4
Female	60	47.6
Others	0	0
TOTAL	126	100

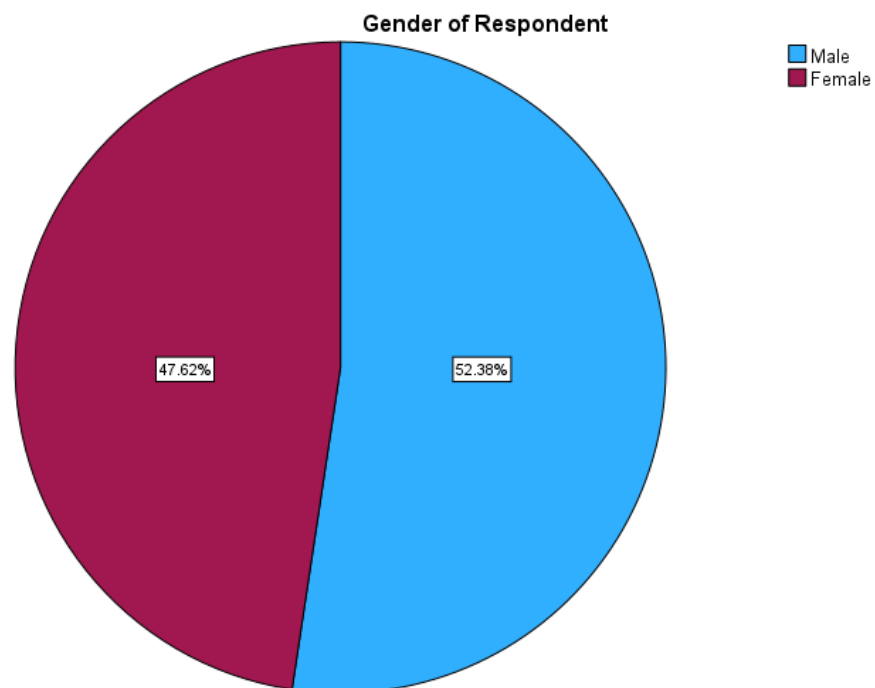


Chart No. 4.1.1. Gender Wise Classification

Inference:

From the above, it can be inferred that 47.6% of the respondents belong to the female category and 52.4% of the respondents belong to the male category.

Table No. 4.1.2 Age Wise Classification

PARTICULAR	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE (%)
Below 25	35	27.8
25-34	29	23.0
35-44	32	25.4
45-54	19	15.1
55 and above	11	8.7
TOTAL	106	100

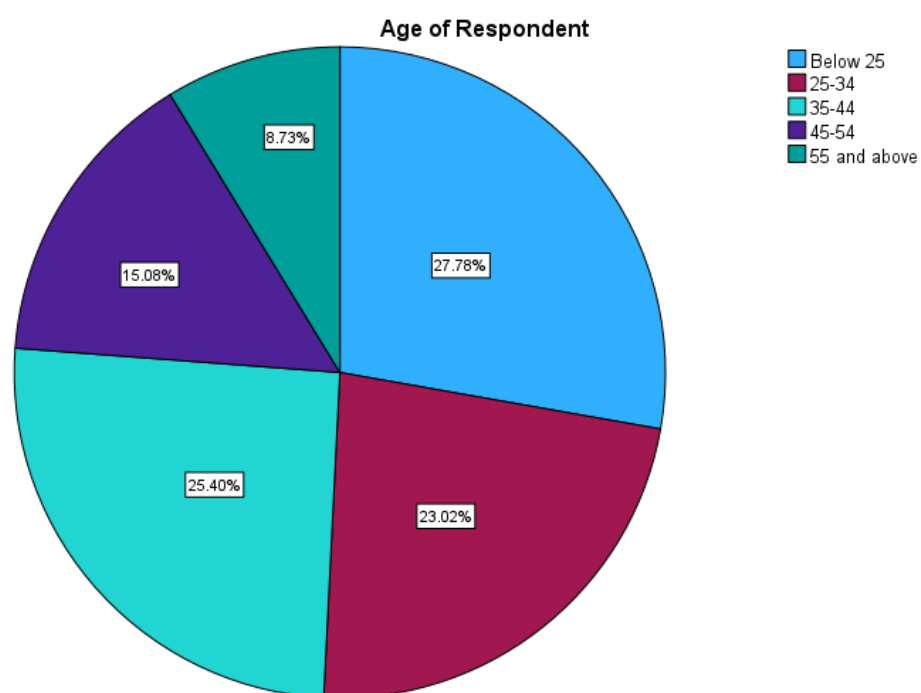


Chart No. 4.1.2. Age Wise Classification

Inference:

From the above table, it is inferred that 27.8% of respondents belong to the age group of Below 25 years. Then 23.0% of respondents belong to the age group of 25 – 34 years, 25.4 % of respondents belong to the age group of 35 – 44 years, then 15.1% of the respondents belong to the age group of 45 – 54 years, 8.7 % of the respondents belong to the age group of 55 and above.

Table No. 4.1.3 Educational Background

PARTICULAR	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE (%)
Secondary/Higher Secondary	17	13.5
Diploma	24	19.0
Bachelor's degree	27	21.4
Master's degree	41	32.5
PhD	17	13.5
TOTAL	126	100.0

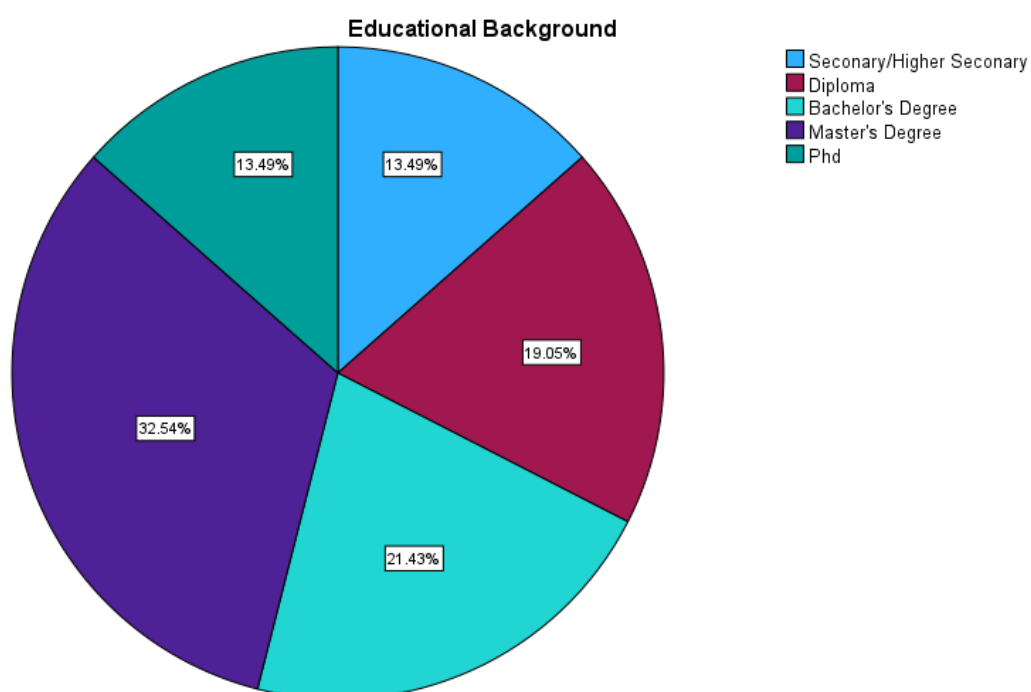


Chart No. 4.1.3. Educational Background

Inference:

This data shows that 13.5% of employees have completed Secondary/Higher Secondary and 19.0% of completed diploma as their minimum education. The majority of respondents, 53.9%, hold either a Bachelor's or a Master's Degree, which indicates that more than half of the workforce has a higher level of formal education. Furthermore, a smaller but notable PERCENTAGE (%) (13.5%) have achieved a PhD, suggesting the presence of highly specialized expertise within the workforce.

Table No. 4.1.4 Marital Status

PARTICULARS	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE (%)
Single	68	54.0
Married	49	38.9
Divorced	8	6.3
Widowed	1	.8
TOTAL	126	100.0

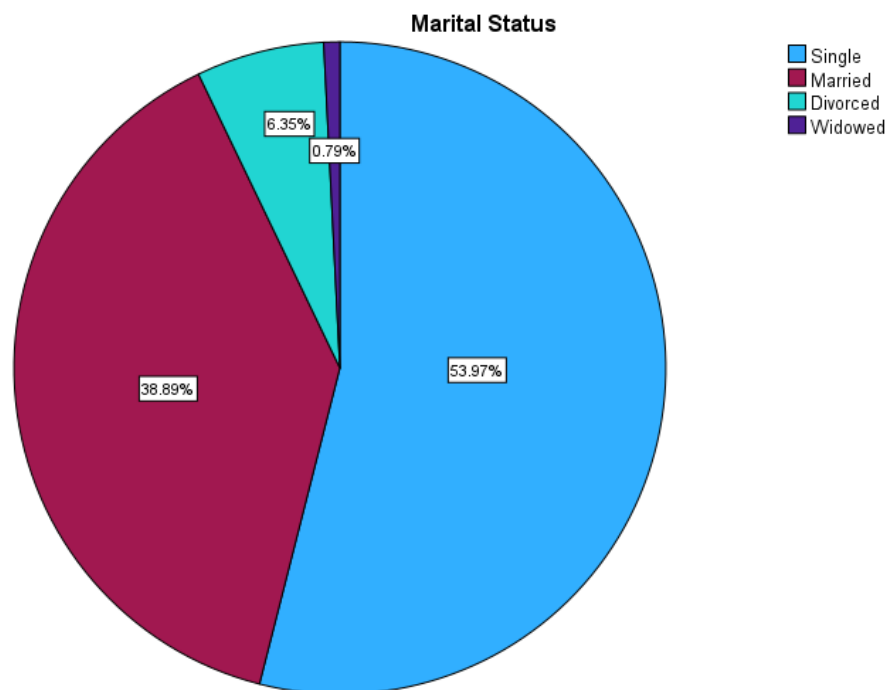


Chart No. 4.1.4. Marital Status

Inference:

The majority of respondents, 54% are single. A significant portion of respondents, 38.9%, are married. Furthermore, a smaller but notable PERCENTAGE (%) (6.3%) are divorced and .8% employees have been widowed.

Table No. 4.1.5 Current Job Position

PARTICULARS	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE (%)
Entry-level	41	32.5
Mid-level	35	27.8
Senior-level	28	22.2
Executive	22	17.5
TOTAL	126	100.0

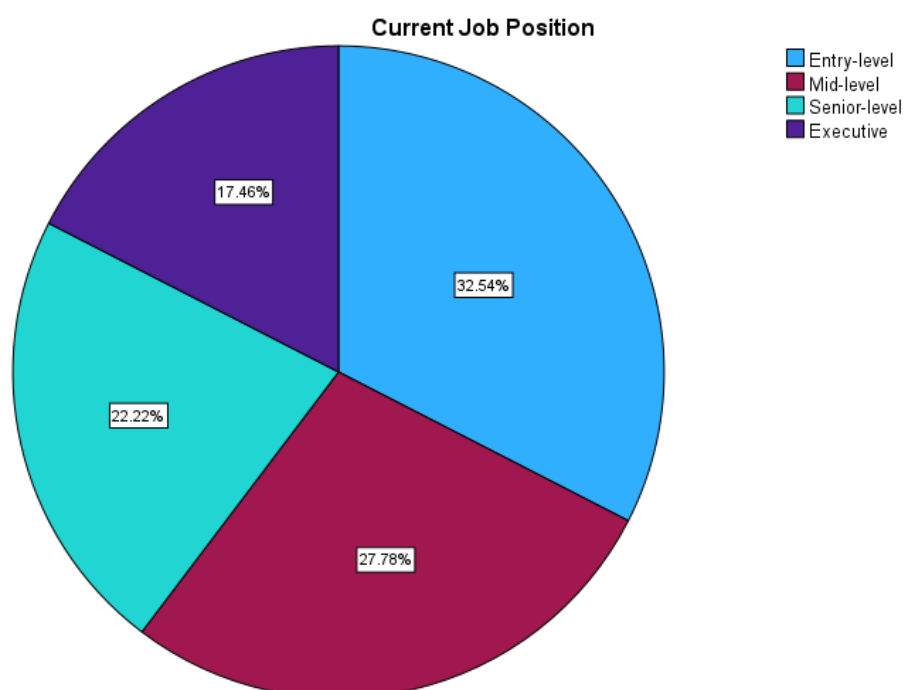


Chart No. 4.1.5. Current Job Position

Inference:

The highest proportion of individuals are at the entry-level, making up 32.5% of the total. Mid-level positions account for 27.8%, indicating a substantial number of employees with moderate experience and responsibilities. Senior-level employees make up 22.2% of the total, showing a smaller but still significant group of highly experienced individuals. The smallest group is at the executive level, comprising 17.5%. This is typical as executive roles are fewer and require extensive experience and leadership skills.

Table No. 4.1.6 Number of Years at the organisation

PARTICULARS	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE (%)
Less than 5 years	45	35.7
5-10 years	18	14.3
10-15 years	22	17.5
15-20 years	20	15.9
More than 25 years	21	16.7
TOTAL	126	100.0

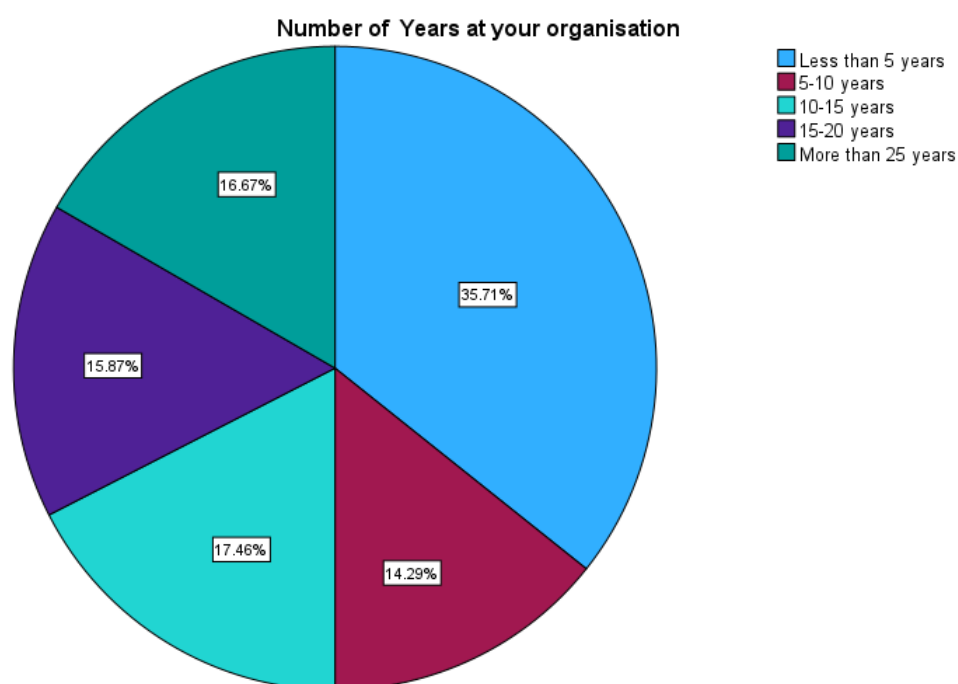


Chart No 4.1.6. Number of Years at the organisation

Inference:

The data reveals that a significant portion of respondents (35.7%) have been in their current organisation for less than 5 years, indicating a relatively new group of employees, which aligns with the 47.2% who have 0-5 years of experience. As tenure increases, 14.3% have been there for 5-10 years, while 17.5% have been in the same organisation for 10-15 years. Additionally, 15.9% have remained for 15-20 years, and 16.7% have been in their current organisation for more than 25 years, indicating a stable group of long-term employees likely occupying senior or executive roles.

Perception of Leadership Roles:

1. Do you believe there are differences in how male and female leaders are perceived by employees at your organisation?

Table No. 4.1.7. Perception of Employees

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Strongly Disagree	21	16.7%
Disagree	19	15.1%
Neutral	28	22.2%
Agree	33	26.2%
Strongly Agree	25	19.8%
Total	126	100.0%

Do you believe there are differences in how male and female leaders are perceived by employees at your organisation?

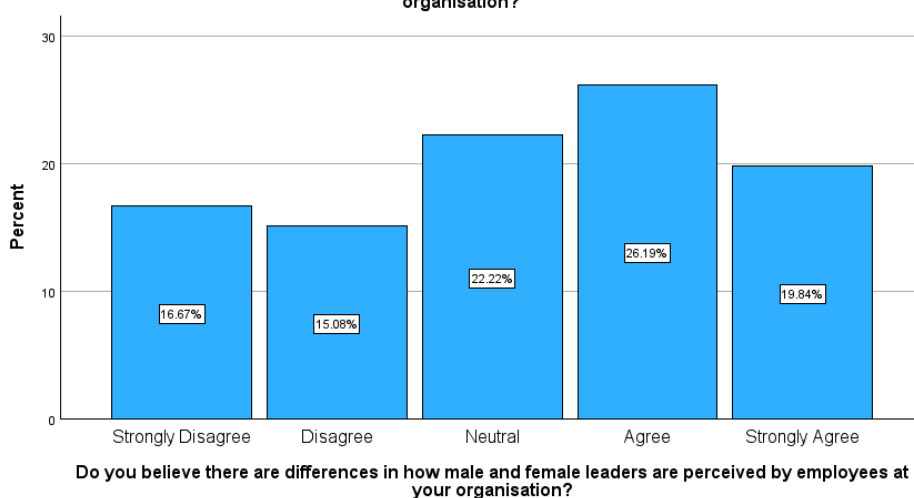


Chart No.4.1.7. Perception of Employees

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 19.8% strongly agree that there are differences in how male and female leaders are perceived, while 26.2% agree with the statement. On the other hand, 22.2% remain neutral, and 31.8% either disagree or strongly disagree with the statement. Thus, the majority of respondents (46%) believe there are differences in the perception of male and female leaders in their organization.

2. How do you think women leaders impact the following aspects of your organisation? - Team Performance

Table No. 4.1.8. Impact of Women Leaders on Team Performance

Response	Frequency	Percent
Negative	22	17.5%
Neutral	26	20.6%
Positive	45	35.7%
Very Positive	33	26.2%
Total	126	100.0%



Chart No. 4.1.8. Impact of Women Leaders on Team Performance

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 26.2% of respondents believe women leaders have a very positive impact on team performance, while 35.7% feel they have a positive impact. Meanwhile, 20.6% remain neutral, and 17.5% believe the impact is negative. Thus, the majority of respondents (61.9%) feel women leaders positively influence team performance.

3. How do you think women leaders impact the following aspects of your organisation? - Morale of Employees

Table No. 4.1.9. Impact of Women Leaders on Employee Morale

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Negative	1	0.8%
Negative	11	8.7%
Neutral	37	29.4%
Positive	41	32.5%
Very Positive	36	28.6%
Total	126	100.0%

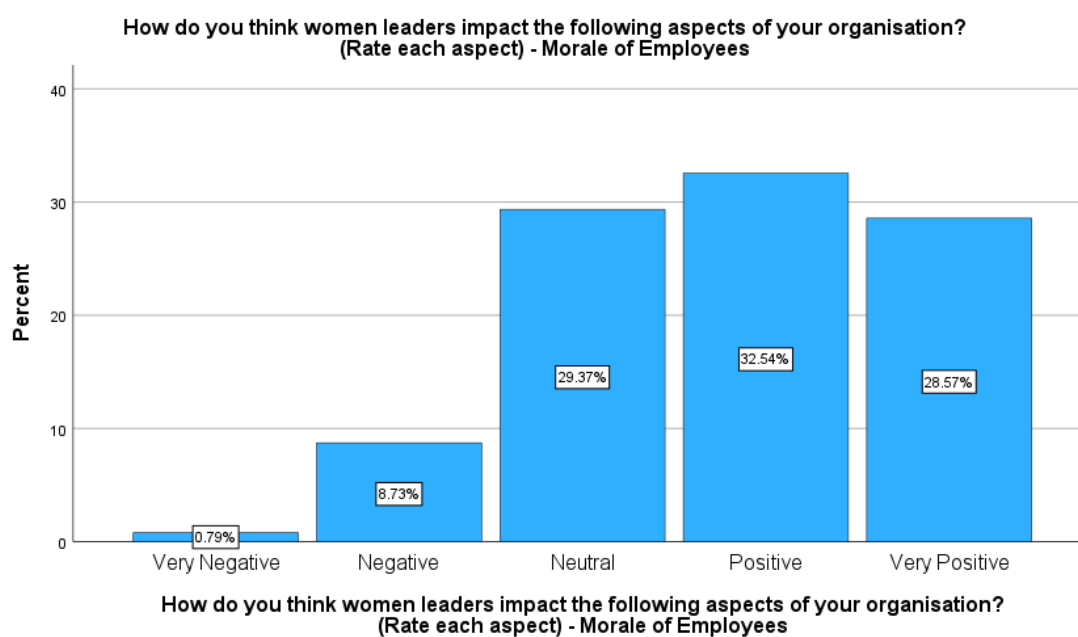


Chart No. 4.1.9. Impact of Women Leaders on Employee Morale

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 28.6% of respondents feel women leaders have a very positive impact on employee morale, while 32.5% believe they have a positive impact. A significant portion, 29.4%, remains neutral, and only 9.5% believe the impact is negative or very negative. Therefore, the majority of respondents (61.1%) perceive that women leaders positively influence employee morale.

4. How do you think women leaders impact the following aspects of your organisation? - Conflict Resolution

Table No. 4.1.10. Impact of Women Leaders on Conflict Resolution

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Negative	1	0.8%
Negative	24	19.0%
Neutral	38	30.2%
Positive	39	31.0%
Very Positive	24	19.0%
Total	126	100.0%

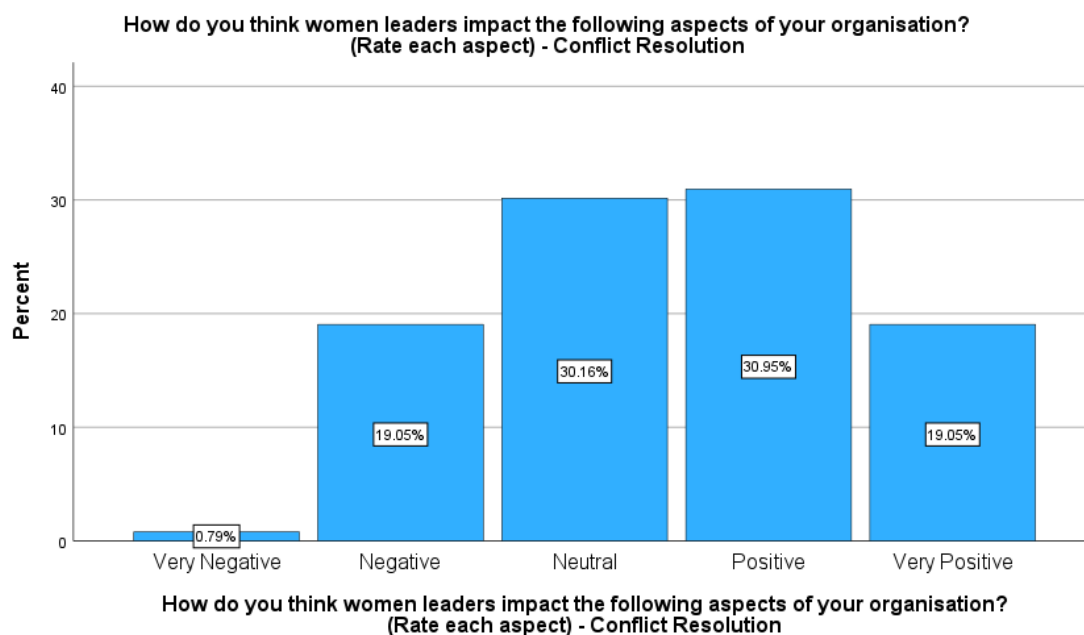


Chart No. 4.1.10. Impact of Women Leaders on Conflict Resolution

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 19% of respondents believe women leaders have a very positive impact on conflict resolution, while 31% feel the impact is positive. However, 30.2% of respondents remain neutral, and 19.8% think the impact is negative or very negative. Thus, the majority of respondents (50%) believe women leaders positively contribute to conflict resolution within their organization.

5. How do you think women leaders impact the following aspects of your organisation? - Creativity

Table No. 4.1.11. Impact of Women Leaders on Creativity

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Negative	21	16.7%
Neutral	42	33.3%
Positive	25	19.8%
Very Positive	38	30.2%
Total	126	100.0%

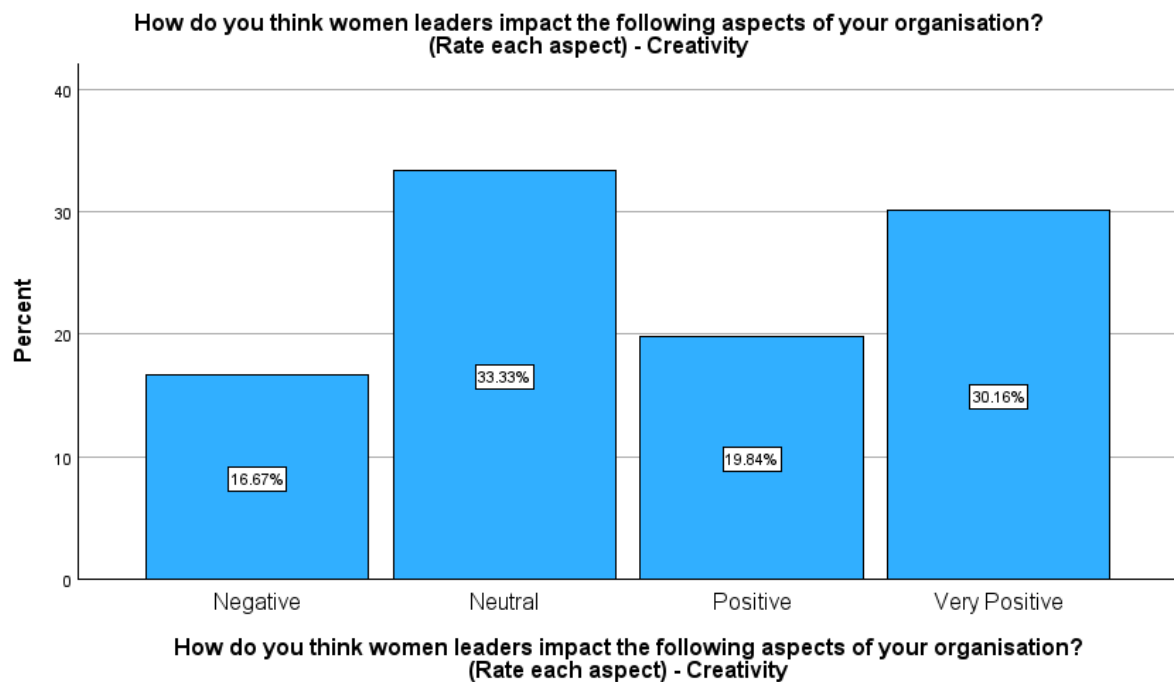


Chart No. 4.1.11. Impact of Women Leaders on Creativity

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 30.2% of respondents believe women leaders have a very positive impact on creativity, and 19.8% feel their impact is positive. A notable 33.3% remain neutral, while 16.7% view the impact as negative. Thus, the majority of respondents (50%) view women leaders as positively contributing to creativity in the organization.

6. How confident are you in your abilities to perform and succeed in a leadership role?

Table No. 4.1.12. Confidence in Leadership Abilities

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Unconfident	21	16.7%
Unconfident	25	19.8%
Somewhat Unconfident	26	20.6%
Neutral	18	14.3%
Somewhat Confident	10	7.9%
Confident	11	8.7%
Very Confident	15	11.9%
Total	126	100.0%



Chart No. 4.1.12. Confidence in Leadership Abilities

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 11.9% of respondents feel very confident in their leadership abilities, while 8.7% are confident and 7.9% are somewhat confident. On the other hand, a significant proportion (57.1%) feels unconfident or somewhat unconfident in their abilities. Thus, a majority of respondents lack high confidence in their leadership potential.

7. Rate your aspiration to pursue a leadership role.

Table No. 4.1.13. Aspiration for Leadership Roles

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Low	48	38.1%
Low	30	23.8%
Neutral	28	22.2%
High	12	9.5%
Very High	8	6.3%
Total	126	100.0%

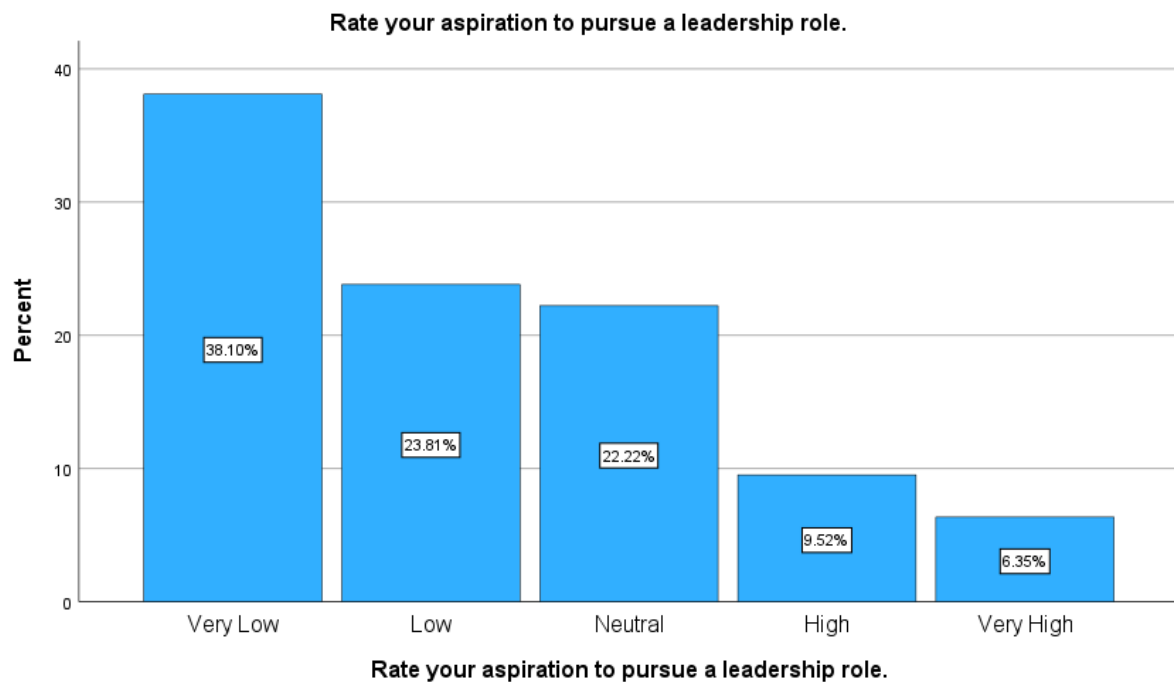


Chart No. 4.1.13. Aspiration for Leadership Roles

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 6.3% of respondents have a very high aspiration to pursue a leadership role, while 9.5% have a high aspiration. However, the majority (61.9%) report low or very low aspiration to pursue leadership roles. This suggests that there may be underlying factors affecting the ambition of employees to seek leadership opportunities.

Leadership Opportunities

8. Do you feel that there are sufficient leadership opportunities available for women at your organisation?

Table No. 4.1.14. Leadership Opportunities

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Strongly Disagree	30	23.8%
Disagree	28	22.2%
Neutral	44	34.9%
Agree	22	17.5%
Strongly Agree	2	1.6%
Total	126	100.0%

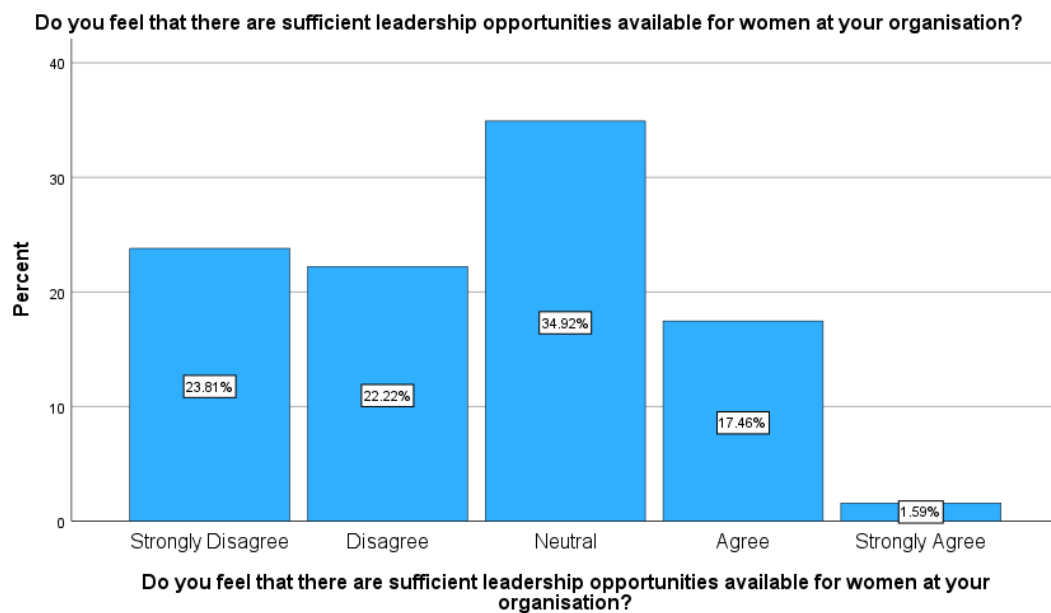


Chart No. 4.1.14. Leadership Opportunities

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 1.6% of respondents strongly agree that there are sufficient leadership opportunities for women, while 17.5% agree. However, the majority (46%) disagree or strongly disagree, and 34.9% remain neutral. This indicates that many respondents feel there are inadequate leadership opportunities for women in the organization.

9. How would you rate the current representation of women in leadership roles?

Table No. 4.1.15. Current representation of Women in Leadership Roles

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Low	11	8.7%
Low	38	30.2%
Neutral	37	29.4%
High	24	19.0%
Very High	16	12.7%
Total	126	100.0%

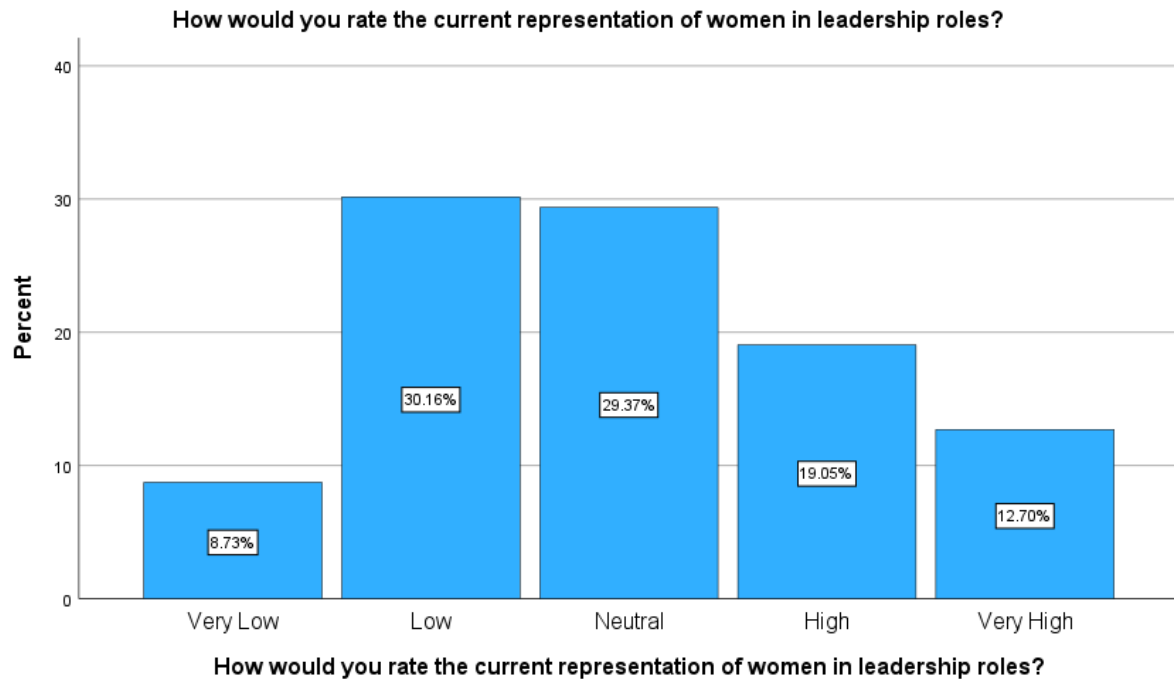


Chart No. 4.1.15. Current representation of Women in Leadership Roles

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 12.7% of respondents rate the representation of women in leadership roles as very high, and 19% rate it as high. However, a considerable portion (38.9%) feels that the representation is either low or very low, with 29.4% remaining neutral. This suggests that opinions on women's representation in leadership roles are quite divided.

10. Do you believe that the number of women in leadership positions has increased in the past 5 years?

Table No. 4.1.16. Increase in number of women in leadership position

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Yes	86	68.3%
No	29	23.0%
Unsure	11	8.7%
Total	126	100.0%

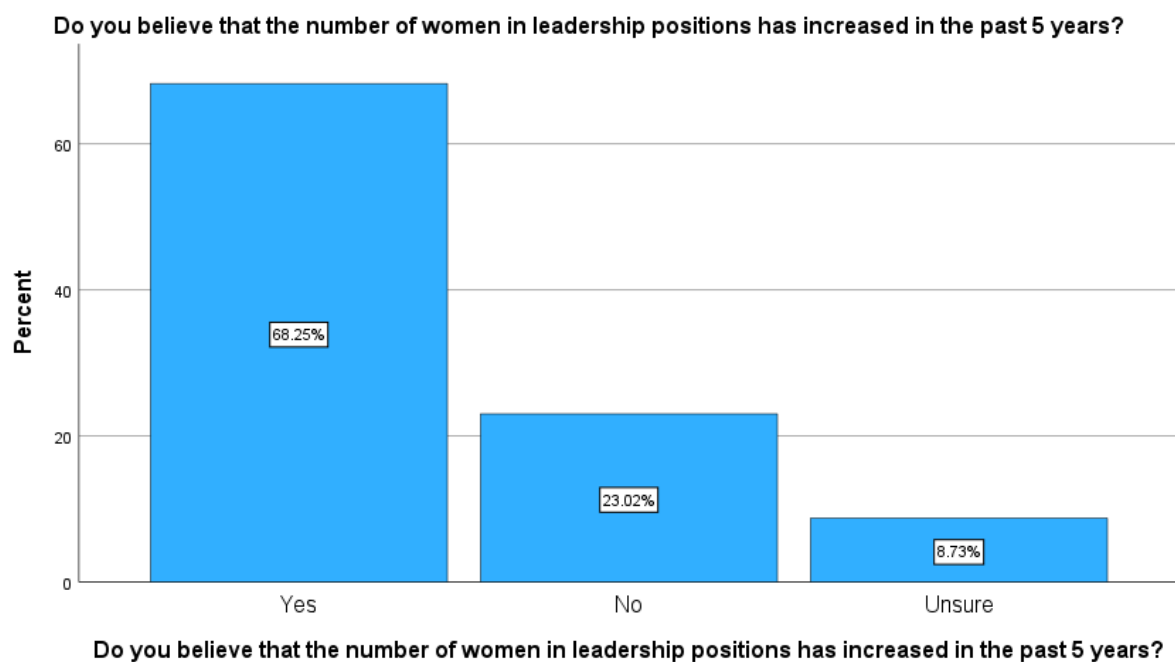


Chart No. 4.1.16. Increase in number of women in leadership position.

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 68.3% of respondents believe that the number of women in leadership positions has increased over the past five years, while 23% believe it has not. A smaller portion, 8.7%, are unsure about this change. Therefore, the majority of respondents perceive a positive trend in women's leadership representation.

Barriers and Challenges

11. Have you encountered any challenges in advancing to leadership positions due to your gender?

Table No. 4.1.17. Challenges in advancing to leadership roles due to gender

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Never	42	33.3%
Sometimes	34	27.0%
Always	50	39.7%
Total	126	100.0%



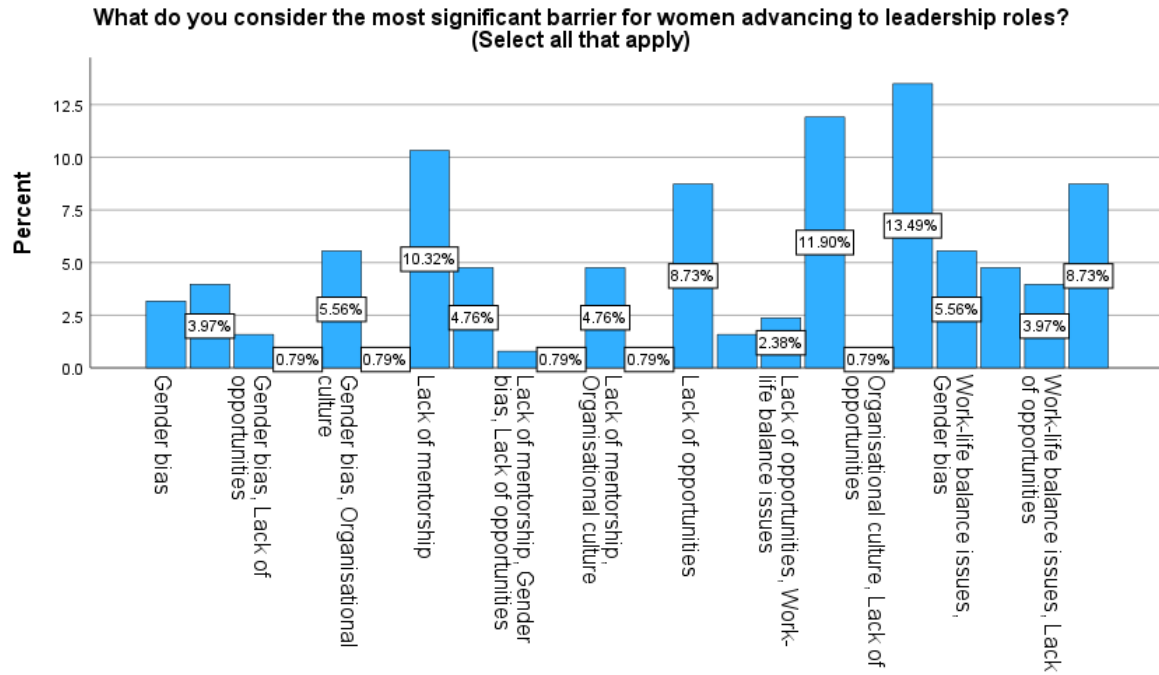
Chart No. 4.1.17. Challenges in advancing to leadership roles due to gender

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 39.7% of respondents have always encountered challenges in advancing to leadership roles due to their gender, while 27% face these challenges sometimes. On the other hand, 33.3% of respondents have never faced such challenges. This suggests that gender-based obstacles remain significant for a large portion of employees.

12. What do you consider the significant barriers for women advancing to leadership roles? (Select all that apply)

Table No. 4.1.18. Significant Barriers for women

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Gender bias	4	3.2%
Gender bias, Lack of mentorship	5	4.0%
Gender bias, Lack of opportunities	2	1.6%
Gender bias, Lack of opportunities, Organisational culture	1	0.8%
Gender bias, Organisational culture	7	5.6%
Gender bias, Work-life balance issues, Organisational culture	1	0.8%
Lack of mentorship	13	10.3%
Lack of mentorship, Gender bias	6	4.8%
Lack of mentorship, Gender bias, Lack of opportunities	1	0.8%
Lack of mentorship, Organisational culture	6	4.8%
Organisational culture	15	11.9%
Work-life balance issues	17	13.5%
Work-life balance issues, Organisational culture	11	8.7%
Total	126	100.0%



What do you consider the most significant barrier for women advancing to leadership roles? ...

Chart No. 4.1.18. Significant Barriers for women

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that the most significant barriers to women advancing to leadership roles include work-life balance issues (13.5%) and organizational culture (11.9%). Lack of mentorship is also a notable factor (10.3%). Gender bias, while still present, is less frequently cited as the sole significant barrier. Thus, challenges related to work-life balance and organizational culture are perceived as the most substantial hurdles.

13. Have you ever felt unsupported by your supervisors or the management when expressing interest in leadership roles?

Table No. 4.1.19. Feeling unsupported by supervisors

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
No	68	54.0%
Yes	58	46.0%
Total	126	100.0%

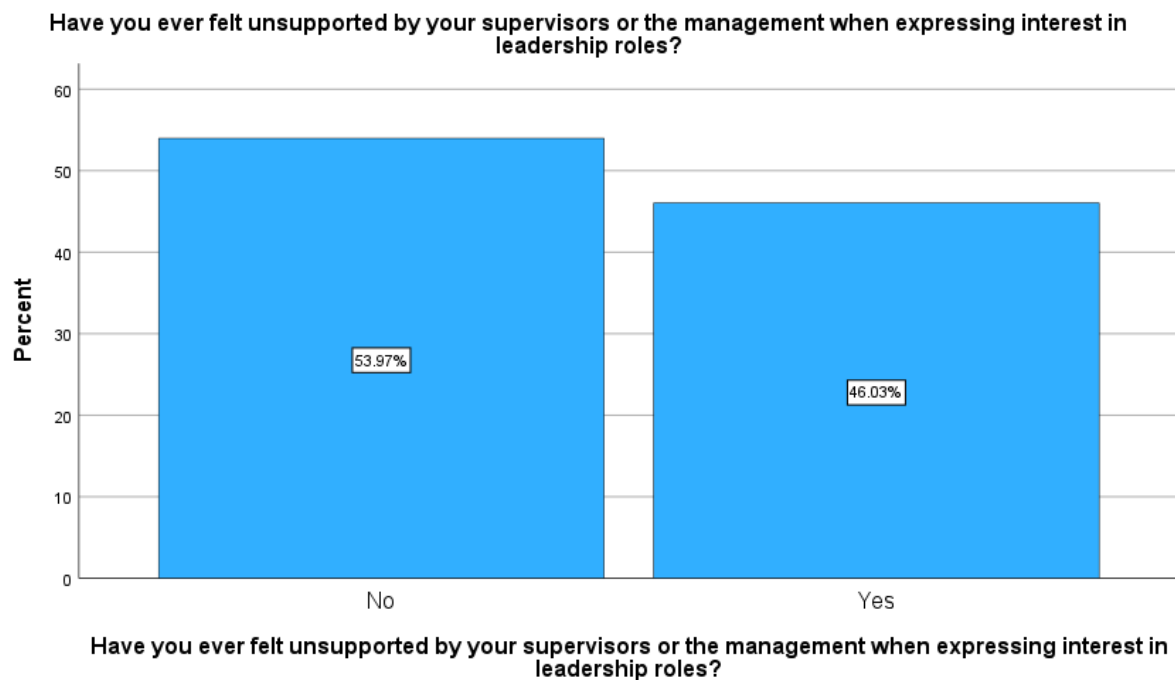


Chart No. 4.1.19. Feeling unsupported by supervisors

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 54% of respondents have not felt unsupported by their supervisors or management when expressing interest in leadership roles, while 46% have felt unsupported. This indicates that almost half of the respondents perceive a lack of support from their leadership when pursuing advancement opportunities.

14. Do you feel that there is no gender bias for leadership roles at your organisation?

Table No. 4.1.20. Gender bias in leadership roles

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Strongly Disagree	2	1.6%
Disagree	17	13.5%
Neutral	39	31.0%
Agree	41	32.5%
Strongly Agree	27	21.4%
Total	126	100.0%

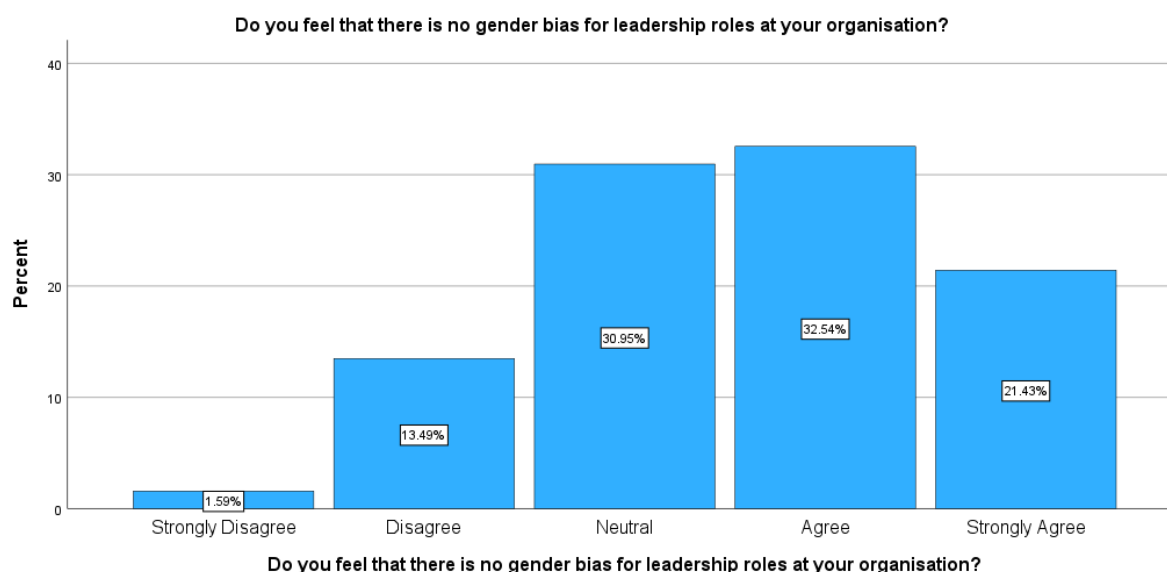


Chart No. 4.1.20. Gender bias in leadership roles

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 32.5% of respondents agree that there is no gender bias for leadership roles at their organization, and 21.4% strongly agree. However, 31% remain neutral, and 15.1% disagree or strongly disagree. This suggests that while the majority believe there is no gender bias, a considerable proportion remains undecided or disagrees.

15. Rate the cultural norms regarding women in leadership positions.

Table No. 4.1.21. Cultural norms regarding women leadership

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Negative	8	6.3%
Negative	41	32.5%
Neutral	37	29.4%
Positive	29	23.0%
Very Positive	11	8.7%
Total	126	100.0%

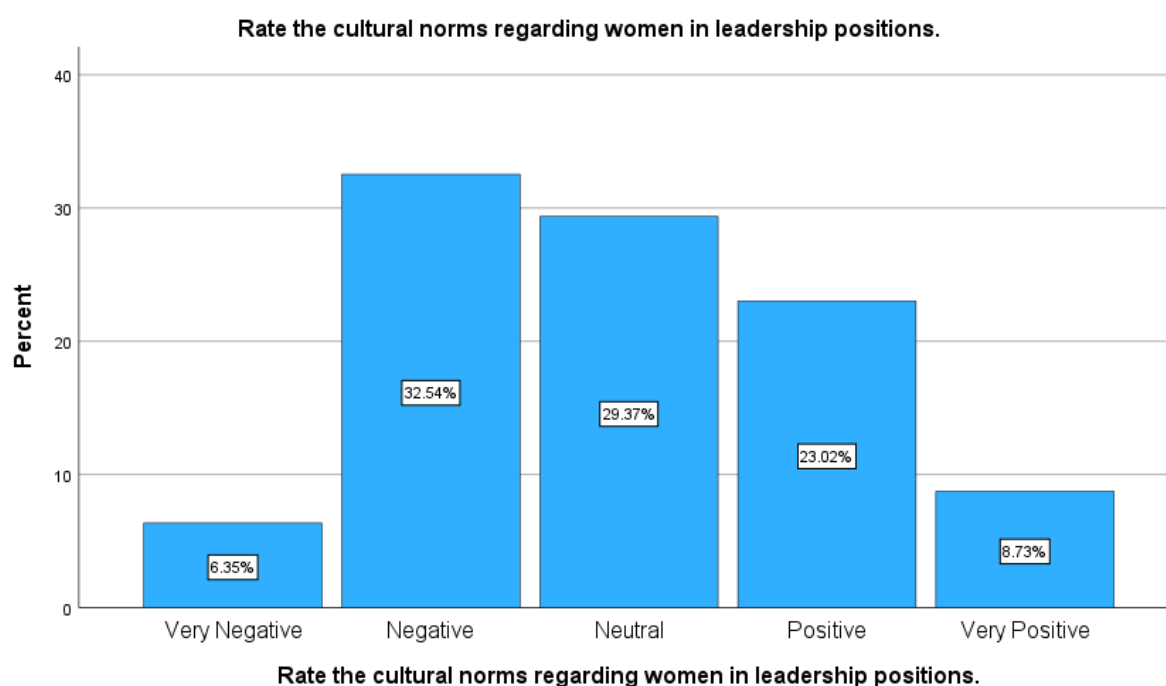


Chart No. 4.1.21. Cultural norms regarding women leadership

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 32.5% of respondents rate the cultural norms regarding women in leadership positions as negative, while 29.4% remain neutral. On the other hand, 23% rate them as positive, and 8.7% as very positive. This shows a mixed view, with a significant portion perceiving the cultural norms as unfavourable.

16. How accessible do you find these leadership opportunities?

Table No. 4.1.22. Accessibility of leadership opportunity

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Inaccessible	9	7.1%
Inaccessible	43	34.1%
Neutral	34	27.0%
Accessible	29	23.0%
Very Accessible	11	8.7%
Total	126	100.0%

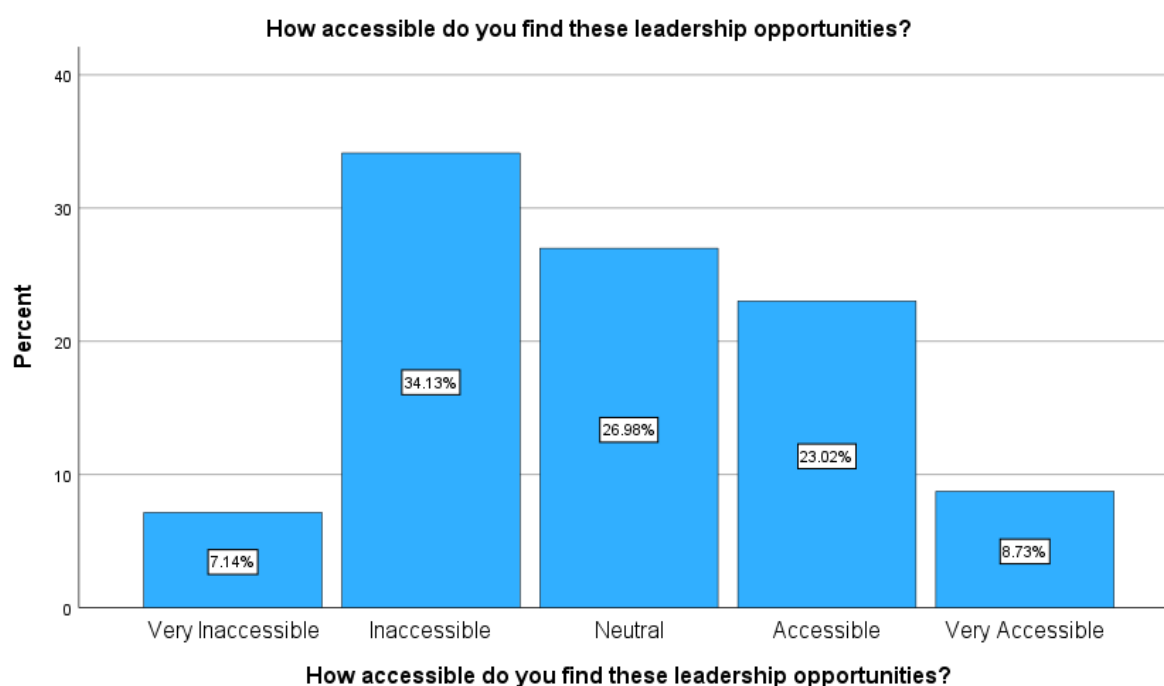


Chart No. 4.1.22. Accessibility of leadership opportunity

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 23% of respondents find leadership opportunities accessible, while 8.7% find them very accessible. However, a significant portion (41.2%) finds them either inaccessible or very inaccessible, and 27% remain neutral. Thus, there is a widespread perception that leadership opportunities are limited in accessibility.

Work-Life Balance

17. How important is work-life balance in influencing your perception of leadership roles?

Table No. 4.1.23. Work-Life balance and perception of leadership roles

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Unimportant	16	12.7%
Somewhat Unimportant	10	7.9%
Neutral	8	6.3%
Somewhat Important	21	16.7%
Important	71	56.3%
Total	126	100.0%

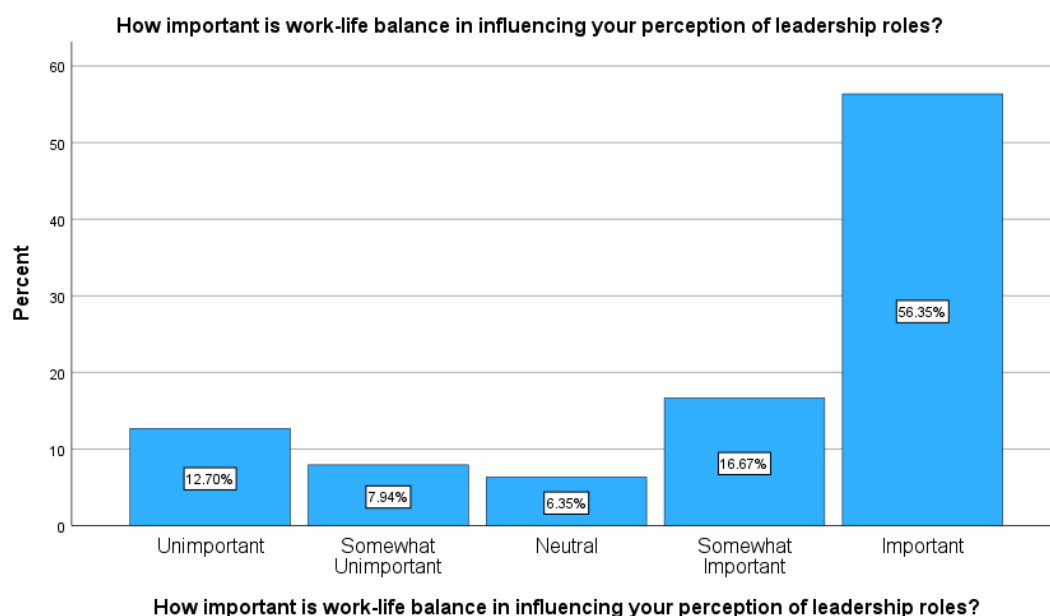


Chart No. 4.1.23. Work-Life balance and perception of leadership roles

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that the majority (56.3%) of respondents find work-life balance important in influencing their perception of leadership roles, with 16.7% viewing it as somewhat important. On the other hand, 20.6% believe it is unimportant or somewhat unimportant. This highlights the significance of work-life balance in leadership aspirations.

18. How well does your organisation support work-life balance for women employees?

Table No. 4.1.24. Organisational Support for Work-Life Balance

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Very Poor	10	7.9%
Poor	53	42.1%
Fair	34	27.0%
Good	10	7.9%
Very Good	19	15.1%
Total	126	100.0%

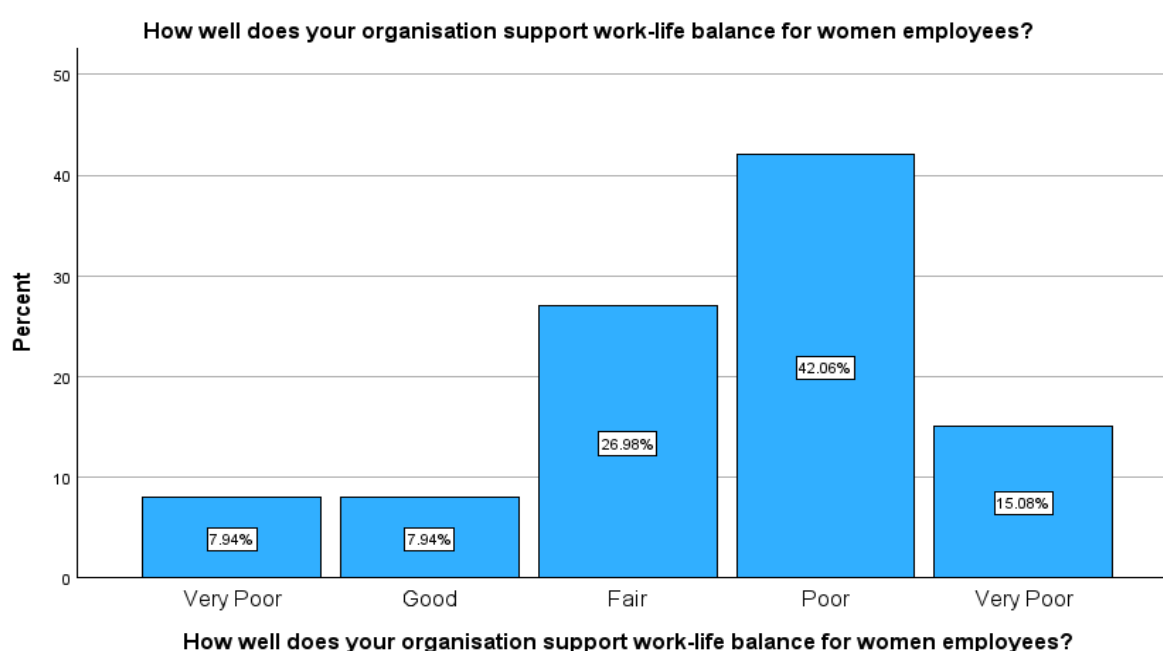


Chart No. 4.1.24. Organisational Support for Work-Life Balance

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 42.1% of respondents rate their organization's support for work-life balance for women as poor, while 7.9% rate it as very poor. Only 7.9% rate the support as good, and 15.1% believe it is very good. Therefore, the majority of respondents feel that their organization offers insufficient support for work-life balance for women.

19. Have you faced any work-life balance issues negatively impacting your chances of pursuing leadership roles?

Table No. 4.1.25. Work-Life balance issues affecting pursuance of leadership

Response	Frequency	Percent (%)
Never	16	12.7%
Rarely	30	23.8%
Occasionally	30	23.8%
Frequently	14	11.1%
Always	36	28.6%
Total	126	100.0%

Have you faced any work-life balance issues negatively impacting your chances of pursuing leadership roles?

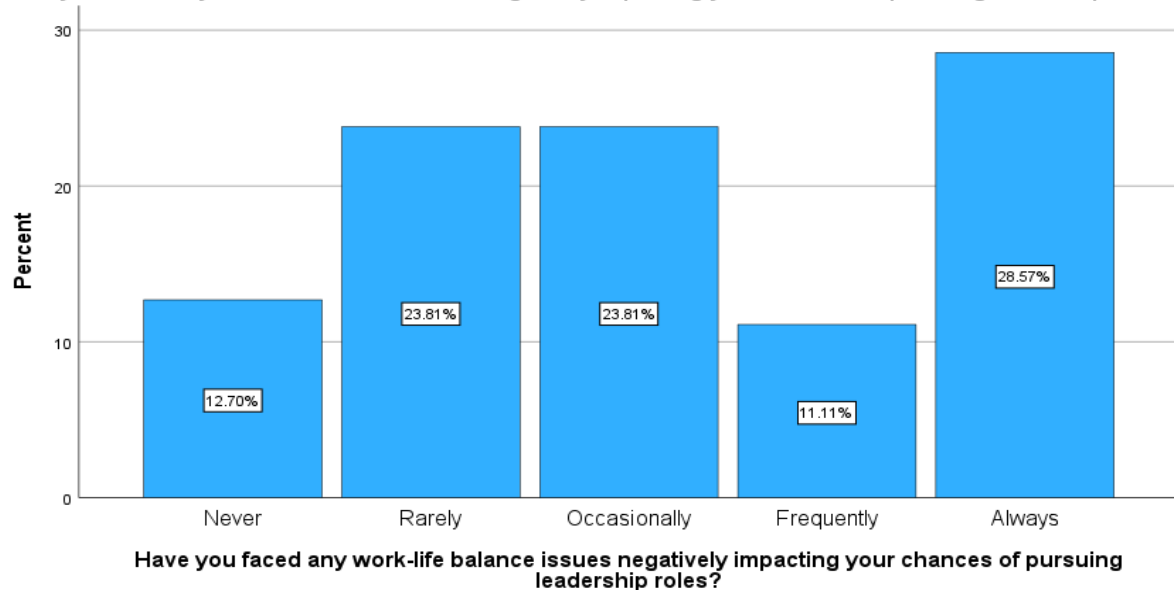


Chart No. 4.1.25. Work-Life balance issues affecting pursuance of leadership

Inference: From the above table, it can be inferred that 28.6% of respondents have always faced work-life balance issues that negatively impacted their chances of pursuing leadership roles, while 11.1% frequently face such issues. Meanwhile, 23.8% report these issues occasionally, and 12.7% never experience them. This indicates that work-life balance challenges are a significant obstacle for many respondents in their leadership aspirations.

4.2. INFERENCE ANALYSIS:

Objective: 1. Explore perceptions of both male and female employees towards women in leadership positions.

Hypothesis 1:

H₀- There is no significant difference in perceptions of women's representation in leadership.

H_a – There is a significant difference in perceptions of women's representation in leadership roles.

Tool Used: One-way ANOVA Test

One-way ANOVA is a statistical technique used to compare sample mean values to determine if there is a statistically significant difference between them. The technique only employs one independent variable.

Table No. 4.2.1 One-way ANOVA table for Years of experience and Employee resilience

ANOVA					
Do you believe there are differences in how male and female leaders are perceived by employees at your organisation?					
	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
Between Groups	7.668	1	7.668	4.235	.042
Within Groups	224.491	124	1.810		
Total	232.159	125			

Inference:

The above table shows that the p-value of the variable gender of the employee and employee perception is 0.042, which is less than 0.05, at the rate of a 5% level of significance. Hence, null hypothesis for these variables is rejected. This means there is a statistically significant difference in perceptions of women's representation in leadership roles.

Objective 2 - Identify Barriers and Challenges women face in advancing to leadership positions.

Hypothesis 2:

H₀: Organisational culture does not significantly impact women's advancement to leadership positions.

H_a: Organisational culture significantly impacts women's advancement to leadership positions.

Table No. 4.2.2. Correlation table for cultural norms and leadership opportunities

Tool Used - Correlations				
			Rate the cultural norms regarding women in leadership positions.	Do you feel that there are sufficient leadership opportunities available for women at your organisation?
Spearman's rho	Rate the cultural norms regarding women in leadership positions.	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	-.67
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.02
		N	126	126
	Do you feel there are sufficient leadership opportunities available for women at organisation?	Correlation Coefficient	-.67	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.02	.
		N	126	126

Inference:

The data shows a negative correlation between the cultural norms regarding women in leadership positions and the perception of sufficient leadership opportunities for women in the organization. Specifically, the Spearman's rho correlation coefficient is -0.67, which indicates a moderate to strong negative relationship which means that as the cultural norms become less favourable towards women in leadership, the perception of available leadership opportunities for women decreases.

Hypothesis 3:

H₀- Work-life balance issues do not significantly affect women's leadership opportunities.

H_a - Work-life balance issues significantly affect women's leadership opportunities.

Table No. 4.2.3. Correlation table for Work-Life Balance and Representation of women

Correlations				
			How well does your organisation support work-life balance for women employees?	How would you rate the current representation of women in leadership roles?
Spearman's rho	How well does your organisation support work-life balance for women employees?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	0.732
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.015
		N	126	126
	How would you rate the current representation of women in leadership roles?	Correlation Coefficient	0.732	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.015	.
		N	126	126

Inference

The data shows a positive correlation between the support for work-life balance for women employees and the representation of women in leadership roles. The correlation coefficient between the two variables is 0.732.

This indicates a strong positive relationship, meaning that as support for work-life balance increases, the representation of women in leadership roles also tends to increase.

Objective 3 – Evaluate the impact of women leaders on various aspects of the organisation.

Hypothesis 4:

H₀ : There is no significant impact of Women Leaderships on team performance, morale, conflict resolution, and creativity.

H_a : There is a significant impact of Women Leaderships on team performance, morale, conflict resolution, and creativity.

Table No. 4.2.1 One-way ANOVA table for Years of experience and Employee resilience.

ANOVA						
		Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
How do you think women leaders impact the Team Performance of your organisation?	Between Groups	.364	1	.364	.332	.565
	Within Groups	135.771	124	1.095		
	Total	136.135	125			
How do you think women leaders impact the Morale of Employees of your organisation?	Between Groups	1.394	1	1.394	1.450	.231
	Within Groups	119.241	124	.962		
	Total	120.635	125			
How do you think women leaders impact the - Conflict Resolution aspects of your organisation?	Between Groups	1.127	1	1.127	1.056	.306
	Within Groups	132.341	124	1.067		
	Total	133.468	125			
How do you think women leaders impact the Creativity of your organisation?	Between Groups	.485	1	.485	.410	.523
	Within Groups	146.721	124	1.183		
	Total	147.206	125			

Inference:

The above table shows that the p-value of the variable team performance, morale, conflict resolution, and creativity are 0.565, 0.231, 0.306, 0.523 respectively which is less than 0.05, at the rate of a 5% level of significance. Hence, null hypothesis for these variables is accepted.

This means there is no statistically significant impact of women leadership on team performance, morale, conflict resolution, and creativity according to this ANOVA analysis.

5.1. Findings:

- Gender: 52.4% of respondents are male, while 47.6% are female.
- Age: The majority of respondents (27.8%) are below 25 years old, followed by 23.0% aged 25-34, 25.4% aged 35-44, and smaller percentages in older age groups.
- Educational Background: Most respondents (32.5%) hold a Master's degree, 21.4% hold a Bachelor's degree, and 19.0% have a diploma, with smaller percentages having secondary or PhD education.
- Marital Status: A slight majority (54.0%) are single, followed by 38.9% who are married, and smaller percentages who are divorced or widowed.
- Current Job Position: 32.5% of respondents are in entry-level positions, 27.8% are in mid-level roles, and the remainder are in senior or executive roles.
- Differences in perception of male and female leaders: The majority of respondents (46%) believe there are differences in how male and female leaders are perceived in their organization.
- Impact of women leaders on team performance: A majority (61.9%) believe that women leaders have a positive or very positive impact on team performance.
- Impact of women leaders on employee morale: Most respondents (61.1%) feel that women leaders positively influence employee morale.
- Impact of women leaders on conflict resolution: Half of the respondents (50%) view women leaders as positively contributing to conflict resolution.
- Impact of women leaders on creativity: Half of the respondents (50%) view women leaders as positively contributing to organizational creativity.
- Confidence in leadership abilities: A significant proportion (57.1%) of respondents feel unconfident or somewhat unconfident in their leadership abilities.
- Aspiration to pursue leadership roles: A majority (61.9%) have low or very low aspirations to pursue leadership roles.
- Sufficiency of leadership opportunities for women: Many respondents (46%) feel there are insufficient leadership opportunities for women.
- Representation of women in leadership roles: Opinions are divided, with 38.9% feeling the representation of women in leadership is low or very low.
- Increase in women in leadership roles in the last 5 years: Most respondents (68.3%) believe the number of women in leadership positions has increased.

- Challenges in advancing to leadership roles due to gender: Many respondents (39.7%) always encounter gender-based challenges in advancing to leadership positions.
- Significant barriers to women advancing to leadership roles: The most significant barriers are work-life balance issues (13.5%) and organizational culture (11.9%).
- Support from supervisors for leadership roles: Nearly half of the respondents (46%) feel unsupported by their supervisors when expressing interest in leadership roles.
- Perception of gender bias in leadership roles: The majority (53.9%) believe there is no gender bias, but a significant portion remains neutral or disagrees.
- Cultural norms regarding women in leadership: Cultural norms are perceived as negative by 32.5% of respondents.
- Accessibility of leadership opportunities: A large proportion (41.2%) find leadership opportunities inaccessible or very inaccessible.
- Importance of work-life balance in leadership perception: Most respondents (56.3%) find work-life balance very important in shaping their perception of leadership roles.
- Organizational support for work-life balance for women: A majority (42.1%) rate their organization's support for work-life balance for women as poor.
- Work-life balance issues affecting leadership opportunities: A significant portion (39.7%) frequently face work-life balance issues that negatively impact their leadership ambitions.

Statistical Findings:

Spearman's Rank Correlation:

Cultural norms regarding women in leadership vs leadership opportunities:

- The Spearman's rho correlation coefficient is -0.67 with a p-value of 0.02.
- This indicates a moderate to strong negative correlation, meaning that as cultural norms become less favorable towards women in leadership, the perception of available leadership opportunities for women decreases.

Support for work-life balance vs representation of women in leadership:

- The Spearman's rho correlation coefficient is 0.732, with a p-value of 0.015.
- This shows a strong positive correlation, meaning that as support for work-life balance increases, the representation of women in leadership also increases.

ANOVA Tests:

Perception of male and female leaders:

- The ANOVA test showed a significant difference in how male and female leaders are perceived, with a p-value of 0.042 (less than 0.05).
- This indicates that there is a statistically significant difference in perceptions based on gender

Impact of women leadership on team performance, morale, conflict resolution, and creativity:

- The p-values for these variables were 0.565, 0.231, 0.306, and 0.523, respectively.
- Since all p-values are greater than 0.05, the null hypothesis is accepted, meaning there is no statistically significant impact of women's leadership on these organizational factors
- These statistical findings highlight both the barriers and positive correlations related to women in leadership, particularly in areas like organizational culture, work-life balance, and employee perceptions.

5.2. Suggestions:

Enhancing Organizational Culture:

Organizations need to cultivate an inclusive culture that actively supports and encourages women in leadership roles. This can be achieved by providing gender-sensitivity training, promoting role models, and ensuring that leadership opportunities are equally accessible to both men and women.

Work-Life Balance Support:

Since work-life balance significantly affects women's leadership opportunities, organizations should enhance policies that support flexibility. Offering options such as remote work, flexible hours, and comprehensive maternity/paternity leave can encourage more women to aspire to leadership roles while managing personal responsibilities.

Address Gender Bias and Stereotypes:

Organizations should focus on creating unbiased recruitment and promotion processes. Gender biases that affect decision-making should be minimized through objective performance evaluations, transparent hiring procedures, and the use of blind recruitment where applicable.

Leadership Development Programs:

Leadership training programs tailored to women can help increase confidence and skills needed for higher roles. These programs should focus on enhancing critical leadership competencies like strategic thinking, decision-making, conflict resolution, and team management.

Encourage Aspiration and Confidence:

Organizations should work to foster an environment where women feel more confident in their leadership abilities. Hosting workshops, talks, and leadership seminars focusing on building self-confidence and encouraging women to take risks in their career progression can help increase aspiration levels among female employees.

5.3. Conclusion:

The research provides a comprehensive understanding of the perceptions of women in leadership roles and the barriers they face within organizational hierarchies. It reveals that while there have been improvements in gender representation in leadership, challenges such as gender bias, work-life balance issues, and insufficient mentorship continue to impede women's progress.

Key findings highlight the importance of organizational culture, work-life balance, and mentorship as pivotal factors that influence women's leadership opportunities. There is a significant correlation between supportive organizational practices (such as work-life balance initiatives) and higher representation of women in leadership. Moreover, women perceive clear differences in how male and female leaders are viewed, signalling an area for addressing entrenched stereotypes.

In conclusion, for organizations to foster greater gender diversity in leadership, they must address these barriers through strategic policy shifts, cultural transformation, and the implementation of focused programs aimed at enhancing women's leadership potential. By doing so, companies not only support gender equality but also benefit from the diverse perspectives and innovative solutions that a gender-diverse leadership team can provide.

CHAPTER – 5

FINDINGS

AND

CONCLUSION

APPENDICES

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Research Questionnaire:

A STUDY ON THE PERCEPTION OF WOMEN EMPLOYEES TOWARDS LEADERSHIP ROLES WITHIN THE ORGANISATIONAL HIERARCHY

Dear Participant,

You are invited to participate in a research study titled "A STUDY ON THE PERCEPTION OF WOMEN EMPLOYEES TOWARDS LEADERSHIP ROLES WITHIN THE ORGANISATIONAL HIERARCHY".

This study aims to explore and understand the views, experiences, and challenges faced by women employees regarding leadership roles within the organisation.

Your participation will provide valuable insights into the factors that influence these perceptions and help identify areas for improvement to support women in leadership positions.

Purpose of the Study:

The primary objective of this research is to gather comprehensive data on the perceptions of women employees towards leadership roles.

Confidentiality:

Your responses will be kept confidential and anonymous. Data collected from this questionnaire will be used solely for research purposes.

Thank you for your time and valuable contribution to this research.

* Indicates required question.

1. * **Gender:**

Male | Female | Others

2. * **Age:**

Below 25 | 25-34 | 35-44 | 45-54 | 55 and above

3. * **Educational Background:**

Secondary/Higher Secondary | Diploma | Bachelor's Degree | Master's Degree | Doctorate

4. * **Marital Status:**

Single | Married | Divorced | Widowed

5. * **Current Job Position:**

Entry-level | Mid-level | Senior-level | Executive

6. * **Number of Years at your organisation:**

Less than 5 years | 5-10 years | 10-15 years | 15-20 years | More than 20 years

7. * **Do you believe there are differences in how male and female leaders are perceived by employees at your organisation?**

Strongly Disagree | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Strongly Agree

8. * How do you think women leaders impact the following aspects of your organisation? (Rate each aspect)

Team Performance - Very Positive | Positive | Neutral | Negative | Very Negative

Morale of Employees- Very Positive | Positive | Neutral | Negative | Very Negative

Conflict Resolution- Very Positive | Positive | Neutral | Negative | Very Negative

Creativity- Very Positive | Positive | Neutral | Negative | Very Negative

9. * How confident are you in your abilities to perform and succeed in a leadership role?

Very Confident | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | Very Unconfident

10. * Rate your aspiration to pursue a leadership role.

Very High | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Very Low

11. * Do you feel that there are sufficient leadership opportunities available for women at your organisation?

Strongly Agree | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Strongly Disagree

12. * How would you rate the current representation of women in leadership roles?

Very High | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Very Low

13. * Do you believe that the number of women in leadership positions has increased in the past 5 years?

Yes | No | Unsure

14. * Have you encountered any challenges in advancing to leadership positions due to your gender?

Never | Sometimes | Always

15. * What do you consider the most significant barrier for women advancing to leadership roles? (Select all that apply)

Lack of mentorship

Gender bias

Work-life balance issues

Lack of opportunities

Organisational culture

16. * Have you ever felt unsupported by your supervisors or the management when expressing interest in leadership roles?

No | Yes

17. * Do you feel that there is no gender bias for leadership roles at your organisation?

Strongly Agree | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Strongly Disagree

18. * Rate the cultural norms regarding women in leadership positions.

Very Positive | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Very Negative

19. * How accessible do you find these leadership opportunities?

Very Accessible | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | Very Inaccessible

20. * How important is work-life balance in influencing your perception of leadership roles?

Important | Somewhat Important | Neutral | Somewhat Unimportant | Unimportant

21. * How well does your organisation support work-life balance for women employees?

Excellent | Good | Fair | Poor | Very Poor

22. * Have you faced any work-life balance issues negatively impacting your chances of pursuing leadership roles?

Always | Frequently | Occasionally | Rarely | Never

23. * Any additional comments or suggestions for improving the women representation in leadership roles at your organisation?